

The Great Works Course: full reading plan

From the Essential Reading List. Tick the boxes as you go; links open in your browser.

An eleven-phase course through every work in README.md. Each phase has a core sequence (read in order) and a deeper shelf (the rest of that phase's sections, read as interest and time allow). Hour figures are rough reading-time estimates for the suggested portion of each work, not for complete editions.

Core sequence: 206 works, about 2,502 hours. Deeper shelves: the remaining works of each phase's sections.

Each core work lists a recommended edition and places to find it. The search links are queries, not specific copies, so check the translator named before you borrow or buy.

Contents

1. Phase I: Tools of Thought (6 core works, ~63 h)
2. Phase II: The Greek World (11 core works, ~225 h)
3. Phase III: Rome (15 core works, ~195 h)
4. Phase IV: Scripture and the Early Church (19 core works, ~201 h)
5. Phase V: The Middle Ages (22 core works, ~232 h)
6. Phase VI: Judaism and Islam (24 core works, ~277 h)
7. Phase VII: India, China, and Japan (30 core works, ~257 h)
8. Phase VIII: Renaissance and the New Science (20 core works, ~251 h)
9. Phase IX: Enlightenment to the Twentieth Century (26 core works, ~335 h)
10. Phase X: The Modern Imagination (25 core works, ~397 h)
11. Phase XI: Capstone: The Forbidden Shelf (8 core works, ~69 h)

Phase I: Tools of Thought

4th c. BC to 13th c.. About 63 hours of core reading.

The medieval curriculum began with the language arts and the mathematical arts before any major author. This phase is short on purpose: learn the vocabulary of logic (genus, species, predication, syllogism), the parts of rhetoric, and the method of a geometric proof. Every later phase uses them.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What is the difference between a valid argument and a true conclusion?
2. What are the five canons of rhetoric, and which one does modern writing neglect?
3. Why did Euclid's method become the model of certain knowledge for later philosophers?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Porphyry — Isagoge** (~3 h)

Read: Read it first; it was the standard primer before Aristotle. Learn the five predicables and note the unanswered question about universals.

Edition: Tr. Jonathan Barnes, *Porphyry: Introduction* (Oxford Clarendon Later Ancient Philosophers)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

2. ☐ **Aristotle — Categories** (~5 h)

Read: The ten categories, with close attention to the account of primary and secondary substance in chapter 5.

Edition: Tr. J.L. Ackrill, *Categories and De Interpretatione* (Oxford Clarendon Aristotle Series); also in *The Complete Works of Aristotle*, ed. Barnes (Princeton)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

3. ☐ **Aristotle — the rest of the Organon (On Interpretation, Prior and Posterior Analytics, Topics, Sophistical Refutations)** (~20 h)

Read: On Interpretation 1-9, Prior Analytics I.1-7 (the syllogism), Posterior Analytics I.1-2, and Sophistical Refutations. Skim the Topics.

Edition: *The Complete Works of Aristotle*, ed. Jonathan Barnes, vol. 1 (Princeton); Prior Analytics tr. Robin Smith (Hackett)

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4. ☐ **Anon. (Pseudo-Cicero) — Rhetorica ad Herennium** (~8 h)

Read: The five canons of rhetoric; Book III on the memory palace is the most cited section.

Edition: Tr. Harry Caplan (Loeb Classical Library 403)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

5. ☐ **Cicero — De Oratore; Orator; Topica; Brutus** (~12 h)

Read: De Oratore Book I on the education of the orator. Brutus can wait for Phase 3.

Edition: Tr. James M. May and Jakob Wisse, *Cicero: On the Ideal Orator* (Oxford)

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6. □ **Euclid — Elements** (~15 h)

Read: Book I in full: definitions, postulates, common notions, then work each proposition through to I.47 (the Pythagorean theorem).

Edition: Tr. T.L. Heath, *The Thirteen Books of the Elements* (Dover); Green Lion Press one-volume edition

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Synthesis. In one page, explain how a medieval student would move from grammar to logic to rhetoric, and what each step equips them to do.

Deeper shelf

- □ **Cicero — On Invention (De Inventione)**: An early, incomplete treatise by Cicero on rhetorical invention, the process of finding arguments for a speech. Written in his youth, it draws on earlier Greek rhetorical theory. It was widely studied as a rhetorical handbook in medieval Europe.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **Priscian — Institutes of Grammar (Institutiones Grammaticae)**: A comprehensive Latin grammar composed in the early sixth century AD by the grammarian Priscian of Caesarea. It systematically covers Latin morphology and syntax. It served as a standard grammatical authority throughout the medieval period.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **Servius the Grammarian — Commentary on Virgil**: A line-by-line commentary on Virgil's works, especially the Aeneid, written by the late fourth-century grammarian Servius. It provides historical, mythological, and linguistic notes and preserves information about Roman antiquity not found elsewhere.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **St. Isidore — Etymologies (Etymologiae)**: A twenty-book encyclopedia compiled by Isidore of Seville in the early seventh century, organizing knowledge by the etymology of words. It covers subjects including grammar, law, medicine, and natural history, drawing on earlier classical sources. It was widely copied and used as a reference work throughout the Middle Ages.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **Alcuin of York — Disputatio with Pippin**: A short Latin dialogue in question-and-answer form, attributed to Alcuin, between a teacher and Pippin, son of Charlemagne. It presents definitions of common concepts through riddles and metaphors, such as defining winter as "the exile of summer." It was used as a pedagogical text in the Carolingian period.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **Donatus — Ars Minor; Ars Maior**: Two Latin grammar textbooks written by the fourth-century grammarian Aelius Donatus. The Ars Minor covers the parts of speech in question-and-answer form for beginners, while the Ars Maior treats grammar and rhetorical figures in more depth. They were the standard introductory grammars of medieval Europe.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- □ **Boethius — On Topical Differences; the logical commentaries**: Sixth-century Latin works by Boethius, including translations of and commentaries on Aristotle's logical treatises and Porphyry's Isagoge. On Topical Differences catalogs types of argument, or topics, used in dialectic and rhetoric. These texts transmitted much of Greek logic to the Latin-speaking West before most of Aristotle's original works were available in Latin.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Quintilian — Institutio Oratoria:** A twelve-book treatise on rhetorical education by the first-century Roman teacher Quintilian. It outlines a curriculum for training an orator from childhood through mature practice, covering grammar, style, delivery, and ethical formation. It was rediscovered in complete form in 1416 and influenced Renaissance humanist education.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Martianus Capella — The Marriage of Philology and Mercury:** A fifth-century Latin allegorical work in prose and verse, in which the marriage of Mercury and the maiden Philology is attended by personifications of the seven liberal arts, each delivering a speech summarizing its content. The work established the sevenfold division of the liberal arts, the trivium and quadrivium, used throughout medieval education.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Longinus — On the Sublime:** A Greek treatise on literary style, of disputed authorship (traditionally attributed to "Longinus"), probably composed in the first century AD. It analyzes the sources of sublimity, or grandeur, in writing, including elevated thought, strong emotion, and figures of speech, illustrated with examples from Homer and other authors.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Dionysius Thrax — The Art of Grammar:** A short Greek grammatical treatise attributed to Dionysius Thrax, active in the second century BC, considered the earliest systematic grammar of Greek. It defines the parts of speech and basic grammatical categories and influenced later Greek and Latin grammatical writing.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Isocrates — Against the Sophists; Antidosis:** Prose works by the Athenian rhetorician Isocrates from the fourth century BC. *Against the Sophists* criticizes the teaching methods of rival rhetoric teachers and outlines his own approach; the *Antidosis* defends his career and educational philosophy, which combined rhetorical training with civic and ethical formation.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Hermogenes of Tarsus — On Types of Style:** A Greek rhetorical treatise, probably by the second-century rhetorician Hermogenes of Tarsus, analyzing qualities of prose style such as clarity, grandeur, and force, and how they are achieved through diction, word order, and figures. It became a standard textbook in Byzantine rhetorical education.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Bede — On the Art of Metre and On Figures of Speech:** Two short pedagogical works by the eighth-century Northumbrian monk Bede, treating Latin poetic meter and the rhetorical figures found in the Bible and classical texts. They were composed for use in monastic schools in Anglo-Saxon England.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **St. Boethius — On Arithmetic; On Music:** Latin treatises by the sixth-century philosopher Boethius, adapting earlier Greek works, including that of Nicomachus of Gerasa, on number theory and musical theory. *On Music* discusses the mathematical ratios underlying musical intervals and distinguishes several categories of music, including music of the celestial spheres. The works served as standard textbooks for the medieval quadrivium.

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- ☐ **St. Bede — On the Reckoning of Time (De Temporum Ratione):** An eighth-century treatise by the Northumbrian monk Bede on computus, the calculation of the date of Easter, and chronology, including the dating of years from the birth of Christ. It also discusses the physical nature of time and the structure of the calendar.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Pliny the Elder — Natural History:** A thirty-seven-book encyclopedia compiled by the Roman author Pliny the Elder in the first century AD, covering subjects including astronomy, geography, zoology, botany, and mineralogy. Pliny died in 79 AD during the eruption of Mount Vesuvius. The work was widely copied and consulted throughout the medieval period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Alcuin of York — Problems to Sharpen the Young (Propositiones ad Acuendos Juvenes):** A collection of mathematical puzzles attributed to Alcuin of York, an eighth-century scholar at the court of Charlemagne. It includes problems such as river-crossing puzzles and questions about measuring quantities, and is considered among the earliest recreational mathematics texts in the Latin tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Nicomachus of Gerasa — Introduction to Arithmetic:** A Greek treatise on number theory by Nicomachus, active around 100 AD, covering properties of numbers such as odd, even, prime, and figurate numbers within a Pythagorean framework. It was translated into Latin by Boethius and became a standard source for arithmetic in medieval education.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Ptolemy — Almagest; Harmonics:** The Almagest, composed by Claudius Ptolemy in the second century AD, presents a mathematical model of the geocentric universe and remained the standard astronomical reference until the Copernican revolution. His Harmonics addresses the mathematics of musical scales and intervals.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Macrobius — Commentary on the Dream of Scipio:** A Latin commentary written in the early fifth century by Macrobius on the concluding section of Cicero's De Republica. It expands on themes including the harmony of the celestial spheres, the nature of the soul, and cosmology, and was a major channel through which Neoplatonic ideas reached the medieval West.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Aratus — Phaenomena:** A Greek didactic poem composed in the third century BC by Aratus, describing the constellations and weather signs in verse. It was translated into Latin several times, including by Cicero, and a line from it is quoted in the Acts of the Apostles.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Hyginus — Poeticon Astronomicum:** A Latin work traditionally attributed to Hyginus, cataloging the mythological stories associated with each constellation. It served as a reference for classical star-myths in later periods.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Bede — On the Nature of Things (De Natura Rerum):** A short treatise by Bede describing the physical world, including the elements, weather phenomena, and the heavens, drawing on earlier sources such as Pliny and Isidore of Seville. It complements his later work on time-reckoning, De Temporum Ratione.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Archimedes — The Works:** The surviving treatises of the Greek mathematician Archimedes, active in the third century BC, covering topics including the law of buoyancy, the measurement of the circle, the areas and volumes of geometric solids, and, in the Sand-Reckoner, a system for expressing very large numbers. His method of exhaustion anticipated later techniques of integral calculus.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Vitruvius — On Architecture:** A Latin treatise on architecture and engineering by the Roman architect Vitruvius, written in the first century BC. It is the only complete work on architecture to survive from antiquity, covering building materials, construction methods, proportion, and machines, and includes a description of human bodily proportion later illustrated as "Vitruvian Man."

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Apollonius of Perga — Conics:** A Greek mathematical treatise by Apollonius of Perga, active in the third century BC, on conic sections, defining and naming the ellipse, parabola, and hyperbola. Its results were later applied by Johannes Kepler in describing planetary orbits.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Diophantus — Arithmetica:** A Greek mathematical text by Diophantus of Alexandria, probably composed in the third century AD, addressing algebraic equations, particularly those seeking integer or rational solutions. A marginal note by Pierre de Fermat on a copy of this work states what became known as Fermat's Last Theorem.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Aristoxenus — Elements of Harmonics:** A Greek treatise on music theory by Aristoxenus, a student of Aristotle active in the fourth century BC. It analyzes musical scales and intervals based on the perception of trained hearing, in contrast to the purely numerical approach of earlier Pythagorean music theory.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Sacrobosco — On the Sphere (De Sphaera):** A thirteenth-century Latin astronomical textbook by Johannes de Sacrobosco, describing the spherical earth, the celestial spheres, and basic astronomical phenomena. It was a standard university text on astronomy in Europe for several centuries.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

Phase II: The Greek World

8th to 4th c. BC. About 225 hours of core reading.

Homer is the shared reference point for everything that follows in the Western sections. Read the poets, then the historians, then the philosophers, in roughly the order they wrote. Plato and Aristotle answer questions the tragedians and historians raised.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What does Achilles want, and does he get it?
2. How do the tragedians treat the conflict between family obligation and the law of the city?
3. Thucydides and Plato both lived through the Peloponnesian War. What did each conclude from it?
4. How does Aristotle's account of the good life differ from Plato's?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Homer — The Iliad; The Odyssey** (~40 h)

Read: Iliad first. Mark Book 9 (the embassy), Book 18 (the shield), and Book 24 (Priam and Achilles). Then the Odyssey, tracking hospitality and homecoming.

Edition: Iliad tr. Richmond Lattimore (Chicago) or Robert Fagles (Penguin); Odyssey tr. Lattimore (Harper) or Emily Wilson (Norton)

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2. ☐ **Hesiod — Theogony; Works and Days** (~4 h)

Read: Theogony for the genealogy of the gods; Works and Days for the ethic of labor and justice.

Edition: Tr. M.L. West, Theogony and Works and Days (Oxford World's Classics)

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3. ☐ **Aeschylus — The Oresteia; Prometheus Bound** (~8 h)

Read: Read the Oresteia as one trilogy. The Eumenides ends a cycle of vengeance with a court at Athens.

Edition: Tr. Richmond Lattimore, in The Complete Greek Tragedies (Chicago); or tr. Robert Fagles (Penguin)

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4. ☐ **Sophocles — The Theban Plays; Ajax** (~8 h)

Read: Oedipus the King, Oedipus at Colonus, Antigone. Antigone sets divine law against the decree of the city.

Edition: Tr. Robert Fagles, The Three Theban Plays (Penguin); or David Grene, Sophocles I (Chicago)

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5. ☐ **Euripides — The Tragedies** (~10 h)

Read: Medea, Hippolytus, The Trojan Women, The Bacchae.

Edition: The Complete Greek Tragedies: Euripides, ed. Grene and Lattimore (Chicago)

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6. ☐ **Aristophanes — The Comedies** (~5 h)

Read: The Clouds first; its caricature of Socrates is the counterpart to Plato's portrait. Then The Frogs and Lysistrata.

Edition: Tr. Peter Meineck, Clouds (Hackett); or Alan Sommerstein, Lysistrata and Other Plays (Penguin)

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7. ☐ **Herodotus — The Histories** (~30 h)

Read: Books I-II for method and digression, VII-IX for the Persian invasion.

Edition: The Landmark Herodotus, ed. Robert Strassler, tr. Andrea Purvis (Anchor)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

8. ☐ **Thucydides — The Peloponnesian War** (~30 h)

Read: Pericles' Funeral Oration (II.35-46), the plague (II.47-54), the Mytilenean debate (III.36-50), the Melian dialogue (V.84-116), the Sicilian expedition (VI-VII).

Edition: The Landmark Thucydides, ed. Robert Strassler, tr. Richard Crawley (Free Press)

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9. ☐ **The Pre-Socratics (the fragments)** (~5 h)

Read: Heraclitus and Parmenides above all; the problem of change and permanence sets up Plato.

Edition: Ed. and tr. Jonathan Barnes, Early Greek Philosophy (Penguin); or Kirk, Raven and Schofield, The Presocratic Philosophers (Cambridge)

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10. ☐ **Plato — Republic; Symposium; Phaedo; Phaedrus; Timaeus; Gorgias; Laws** (~45 h)

Read: Suggested order: Gorgias, Phaedo, Symposium, Republic, Phaedrus, Timaeus. Leave the Laws for a later pass. The Apology and Crito, though not listed, are a short useful preface.

Edition: Plato: Complete Works, ed. John M. Cooper (Hackett). Republic tr. Allan Bloom (Basic Books) or Grube/Reeve (Hackett)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

11. ☐ **Aristotle — Nicomachean Ethics; Politics; Physics; Metaphysics; On the Soul; Poetics; Rhetoric** (~40 h)

Read: Nicomachean Ethics in full; then Politics I-III, Poetics, On the Soul II-III, Physics II, Metaphysics I and XII.

Edition: Nicomachean Ethics tr. Terence Irwin (Hackett) or Bartlett and Collins (Chicago); Politics tr. C.D.C. Reeve (Hackett); Poetics tr. Joe Sachs (Focus)

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Synthesis. Trace one idea (justice, fate, or the good life) from Homer through the tragedians to Plato and Aristotle.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **The Homeric Hymns:** A collection of anonymous Greek hymns in epic style, addressed to various gods, composed between roughly the seventh and fourth centuries BC. They include narrative episodes such as the abduction of Persephone in the Hymn to Demeter and the infancy of Hermes.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Apollonius of Rhodes — Argonautica:** A Hellenistic Greek epic poem by Apollonius of Rhodes, composed in the third century BC, recounting Jason's quest for the Golden Fleece with the Argonauts and his relationship with the sorceress Medea. It is noted for its detailed portrayal of Medea's internal conflict and later influenced Roman epic, including Virgil's Aeneid.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Pindar — Odes:** Choral odes composed by the Greek poet Pindar in the fifth century BC, celebrating victors in athletic competitions including the Olympic and Pythian games. They combine praise of the victor with mythological narrative and reflections on human achievement and mortality.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Sappho — Fragments:** Surviving fragments of lyric poetry by the Greek poet Sappho, active on the island of Lesbos around 600 BC. Her poems, largely preserved incompletely through quotation and papyrus finds, deal chiefly with themes of love and desire, often directed toward women.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Aesop — The Fables:** A collection of short prose fables traditionally attributed to Aesop, said to have lived in Greece in the sixth century BC, though the surviving collections were compiled and expanded by later authors. Each fable typically features animal characters and concludes with a moral lesson.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Theocritus — Idylls:** A collection of Greek poems by Theocritus, active in the third century BC, largely set in rural Sicily and featuring shepherds and herdsmen. The Idylls are considered the founding works of the pastoral poetry genre, later imitated by Virgil and other poets.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Callimachus — Hymns; Aetia:** Works by the Alexandrian poet and scholar Callimachus, third century BC. The Hymns are poems addressed to various gods in the epic tradition; the Aetia is a fragmentary elegiac poem exploring the origins of various customs, rituals, and place names. Callimachus favored short, highly polished poetic forms over long epic.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Menander — The Grouch; the comedies:** Plays by the Athenian playwright Menander, fourth-third centuries BC, the principal representative of Greek New Comedy, of which The Grouch (Dyskolos) survives complete. His comedies center on domestic situations, romantic misunderstandings, and stock character types, and influenced Roman comic playwrights such as Plautus and Terence.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **The Greek Anthology:** A large collection of Greek epigrams and short poems by numerous authors, compiled and expanded over roughly a thousand years, from the classical period through the Byzantine era. Its poems address subjects including love, death, art, and everyday life.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Sextus Empiricus — Outlines of Pyrrhonism:** A 2nd-century AD survey of Pyrrhonist skepticism, outlining methods for suspending judgment on matters that cannot be conclusively determined. The text presents opposing arguments on a range of philosophical and scientific questions to demonstrate the case for withholding assent. It is a primary source for ancient skeptical philosophy and was studied during the European Renaissance.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Diogenes Laertius — Lives of the Eminent Philosophers:** A 3rd-century AD compilation of biographical information, sayings, and doctrinal summaries of Greek philosophers from Thales to the Hellenistic schools. It draws on earlier sources, many no longer extant. It remains a primary source of information for several ancient philosophical schools.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Xenophon — Memorabilia; Cyropaedia:** Works by a student of Socrates who was also a soldier and historian of the 4th century BC. The *Memorabilia* is a defense and recollection of Socrates' teaching and character, presenting a more practically oriented portrait than Plato's dialogues. The *Cyropaedia* is a partly fictionalized account of the education and rule of Cyrus the Great, addressing leadership and governance.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Epicurus — Letters and Principal Doctrines:** Surviving letters and maxims of the philosopher (341-270 BC), founder of Epicureanism. The teachings hold that the goal of life is tranquility (*ataraxia*), achieved through the moderate pursuit of pleasure and the removal of fear, particularly fear of death and the gods. Much of Epicurus's original output is lost, and these fragments are preserved largely through later authors such as Diogenes Laertius.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Theophrastus — Characters; the botanical works:** Writings by Aristotle's successor as head of the Lyceum (c. 371-287 BC). The *Characters* is a short collection of sketches describing thirty personality types, such as the flatterer and the boastful man. His botanical treatises, *Enquiry into Plants* and *On the Causes of Plants*, are among the earliest systematic works on plant science.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Philo of Alexandria — On the Creation; Allegorical Interpretation:** Writings of a Hellenistic Jewish philosopher (c. 20 BC-50 AD) who interpreted the Hebrew Bible using categories drawn from Greek philosophy, particularly Platonism. His allegorical method of biblical interpretation influenced later Christian exegetes, including Origen and Clement of Alexandria.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

Phase III: Rome

3rd c. BC to 2nd c. AD. About 195 hours of core reading.

Rome absorbed Greek learning and turned it toward law, duty, and empire. Read the historians of the Republic, then Cicero and the Augustan poets, then the imperial historians and the Stoics. Virgil and Cicero were the two Latin authors every later European student knew.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What does Roman *virtus* mean, and how does it differ from Greek *arete*?
2. Is Aeneas admirable? What does Virgil suggest Rome cost?
3. How do Seneca, Epictetus, and Marcus Aurelius each practice Stoicism differently?
4. What does Tacitus think happened to Roman liberty?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Polybius — The Histories** (~10 h)

Read: Book I for the method, Book VI for the mixed constitution that later shaped Montesquieu and the American founders.

Edition: Tr. Robin Waterfield, *The Histories* (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

2. ☐ **Livy — The History of Rome (Ab Urbe Condita)** (~25 h)

Read: Books I-V (founding to the Gallic sack) and XXI-XXX (the war with Hannibal).

Edition: Tr. Aubrey de Selincourt, *The Early History of Rome and The War with Hannibal* (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

3. ☐ **Plutarch — Parallel Lives; Moralia** (~25 h)

Read: Paired Lives: Theseus/Romulus, Lycurgus/Numa, Alexander/Caesar, Demosthenes/Cicero. Dip into the *Moralia*.

Edition: Tr. Robin Waterfield, *Roman Lives and Greek Lives* (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

4. ☐ **Lucretius — On the Nature of Things (De Rerum Natura)** (~10 h)

Read: The Epicurean alternative: atoms, void, and no fear of death (Book III). Rediscovered in 1417.

Edition: Tr. Martin Ferguson Smith (Hackett); or A.E. Stallings (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

5. ☐ **Cicero — On Duties; Tusculan Disputations; On the Nature of the Gods; On Old Age; On Friendship; Letters** (~20 h)

Read: On Duties first, then On Friendship and On Old Age; Tusculan Disputations I and V; a selection of the Letters.

Edition: On Duties tr. Griffin and Atkins (*Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought*); On Friendship and On Old Age in Cicero: On the Good Life, tr. Michael Grant (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

6. ☐ **Cicero — The Dream of Scipio (Somnium Scipionis) (~1 h)**

Read: The closing myth of Cicero's *On the Republic*. It links Roman public service to Platonic cosmology.

Edition: In *Cicero: The Republic and The Laws*, tr. Niall Rudd (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

7. ☐ **Virgil — The Aeneid (~20 h)**

Read: Books 1-6 (Troy to the underworld), then 7-12 (the war in Italy). Compare Book 6 with *Odyssey* 11.

Edition: Tr. Robert Fitzgerald (Vintage) or Robert Fagles (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

8. ☐ **Horace — Odes; Satires; Epistles; Ars Poetica (~8 h)**

Read: *Odes* I-III, a few *Epistles*, and the *Ars Poetica*.

Edition: Tr. David West, *The Complete Odes and Epodes* (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

9. ☐ **Ovid — Metamorphoses; Fasti; Heroides (~15 h)**

Read: *The Metamorphoses* in full; much later poetry and painting depend on it.

Edition: Tr. Allen Mandelbaum (Harcourt) or Charles Martin (Norton)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

10. ☐ **Seneca — Letters to Lucilius; On the Shortness of Life; Moral Essays (~12 h)**

Read: *Letters* 1-30 and *On the Shortness of Life*.

Edition: Tr. Robin Campbell, *Letters from a Stoic* (Penguin); *On the Shortness of Life* tr. C.D.N. Costa (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

11. ☐ **Tacitus — Annals; Histories; Germania; Agricola (~20 h)**

Read: *Agricola* and *Germania* (both short), then *Annals* I-VI on Tiberius.

Edition: *Agricola* and *Germania* tr. Harold Mattingly (Penguin); *Annals* tr. A.J. Woodman (Hackett)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

12. ☐ **Suetonius — The Twelve Caesars (~8 h)**

Read: *Julius*, *Augustus*, *Tiberius*, *Nero*. Compare his method with Tacitus.

Edition: Tr. Robert Graves, rev. J.B. Rives (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

13. ☐ **Epictetus — Enchiridion; Discourses (~8 h)**

Read: *The Enchiridion*, then *Discourses* Book I. Chapter 1 of the *Enchiridion* is the core distinction.

Edition: Tr. Robin Hard, *Discourses, Fragments, Handbook* (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

14. ☐ **Marcus Aurelius — Meditations** (~5 h)

Read: Read slowly, one book per sitting. Book 1 lists what he learned from each teacher.

Edition: Tr. Gregory Hays (Modern Library) or Robin Hard (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

15. ☐ **Apuleius — The Golden Ass** (~8 h)

Read: The only Latin novel to survive complete. Book 11 on the Isis mysteries anticipates Phase 4's conversion narratives.

Edition: Tr. P.G. Walsh (Oxford World's Classics) or Sarah Ruden (Yale)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

Synthesis. Compare the Roman idea of duty in Cicero and Virgil with the Stoic idea of inner freedom in Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Lucan — Pharsalia (De Bello Civili):** An unfinished Latin epic poem by Lucan (39-65 AD) on the civil war between Julius Caesar and Pompey. Unlike traditional epic, it largely omits divine intervention, focusing instead on political power, fortune, and the collapse of the Roman Republic.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Statius — Thebaid:** A Latin epic poem by Statius, composed in the first century AD, recounting the mythical war between the sons of Oedipus, Eteocles and Polynices, for control of Thebes. It was widely read in the medieval period, and Dante includes Statius as a character and guide in the Purgatorio.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **St. Venantius Fortunatus — Pange Lingua Gloriosi Proelium Certaminis:** A Latin hymn composed by Venantius Fortunatus in the sixth century, celebrating the cross of the crucifixion. Written in classical meter, it was adopted into the liturgy of the Western Church, particularly for Good Friday and Holy Week services.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Virgil — Eclogues; Georgics:** Earlier works by Virgil preceding the Aeneid. The Eclogues (42-39 BC) are pastoral poems depicting shepherds in idealized rural settings; the Georgics (29 BC) is a didactic poem on agriculture, covering farming, viticulture, animal husbandry, and beekeeping. The Fourth Eclogue's prophecy of a child ushering in a new age was later interpreted by some Christian readers as a prefiguration of Christ.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Catullus — Poems:** A collection of Latin poems by Catullus, mid-first century BC, including short lyric and invective verses as well as longer poems in various meters. Many poems address a woman referred to as "Lesbia," generally identified with Clodia Metelli, and treat themes of love, friendship, and personal rivalry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Statius — Silvae; Achilleid:** Additional works by Statius beyond the Thebaid. The Silvae is a collection of occasional poems on subjects including patronage, domestic life, and personal loss; the Achilleid is an unfinished epic on the early life of Achilles, including his time disguised among the daughters of King Lycomedes.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Silius Italicus — Punica:** A Latin epic poem by Silius Italicus, first century AD, the longest surviving poem in Latin, recounting the Second Punic War between Rome and Carthage, including the campaigns of Hannibal.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Valerius Flaccus — Argonautica:** An unfinished Latin epic poem by Valerius Flaccus, first century AD, retelling the story of Jason and the Argonauts' quest for the Golden Fleece. It is modeled on the earlier Greek *Argonautica* of Apollonius of Rhodes but places greater emphasis on the psychological development of Medea.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Juvenal — Satires:** Sixteen satirical poems by the Roman poet Juvenal, late first to early second century AD, addressing the vices, hypocrisies, and social conditions of imperial Rome. They include the phrases "panem et circenses" (bread and circuses) and "quis custodiet ipsos custodes" (who will guard the guards themselves).
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Persius — Satires:** Six satirical poems by Persius (34-62 AD), a Stoic writer whose dense, allusive Latin addresses themes of moral hypocrisy and self-examination in light of Stoic philosophy.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Martial — Epigrams:** A collection of short Latin epigrams by Martial, first century AD, numbering around 1,500, covering subjects from social satire and personal invective to occasional and commemorative verse, and documenting aspects of daily life in Rome.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Claudian — Poems:** Latin poems by Claudian, late fourth to early fifth century AD, a court poet who wrote panegyrics for the Western Roman emperor Honorius and the general Stilicho, and the unfinished mythological epic *The Rape of Proserpina*. He is generally regarded as among the last poets writing within the classical Latin epic tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Prudentius — Psychomachia:** A Latin allegorical poem by the Christian poet Prudentius, late fourth century AD, depicting a battle between personified virtues and vices for possession of the human soul. It is considered an early and influential example of the allegorical genre in Western literature.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Sedulius — Carmen Paschale:** A Latin epic poem by Sedulius, fifth century AD, retelling episodes from the Gospels, particularly the miracles of Christ, in the style and meter of classical Latin epic. It was used as an educational text in medieval schools.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Juvencus — Evangeliorum Libri:** A Latin epic poem by Juvencus, composed in the early fourth century AD, versifying the life of Christ, based primarily on the Gospel of Matthew, in Virgilian hexameters. It is considered the earliest Christian Latin epic.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Plautus & Terence — The Comedies:** Roman comic playwrights of the third and second centuries BC, respectively, both adapting plots from Greek New Comedy. Plautus's plays are marked by broad farce, wordplay, and musical elements, while Terence's are noted for more restrained language and psychological characterization. Their surviving plays center on themes including mistaken identity and clever slaves.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Seneca — The Tragedies:** Latin tragedies attributed to the Stoic philosopher and statesman Seneca the Younger, first century AD, including *Medea*, *Phaedra*, and *Thyestes*, dealing with themes of revenge, tyranny, and extreme passion. They influenced the development of Renaissance tragedy, including English drama.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Ennius — Annales (fragments):** A fragmentary Latin epic poem by Quintus Ennius (239-169 BC), recounting Roman history from the fall of Troy to Ennius's own time in dactylic hexameter, a meter he introduced to Latin poetry. Only fragments survive, quoted by later authors.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Tibullus & Propertius — The Elegies:** Roman love elegists of the late first century BC. Propertius's elegies, addressed largely to a woman he calls Cynthia, are noted for their mythological allusion and intensity; Tibullus's poems combine themes of love with idealized depictions of rural life.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Manilius — Astronomica:** A Latin didactic poem by Manilius, early first century AD, on astronomy and astrology, describing the constellations, the zodiac, and a Stoic-influenced view of a cosmos governed by fate.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Ausonius — Mosella; Poems:** Latin poems by Ausonius, fourth century AD, a Gallo-Roman poet and teacher. The Mosella describes the Moselle River and its surrounding landscape; his other poems address teachers, family members, and daily life. He wrote near the end of the classical Latin literary tradition, in the late Roman period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Sallust — The Catiline War; The Jugurthine War:** Two Latin historical monographs by Gaius Sallustius Crispus, written in the mid-1st century BC. The Catiline War covers the conspiracy of Catiline in 63 BC; the Jugurthine War covers Rome's war against the Numidian king Jugurtha. Both combine narrative with moralizing analysis attributing Rome's political troubles to a decline in traditional discipline.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Julius Caesar — The Gallic War; The Civil War:** First-person military narratives authored by Julius Caesar, covering his campaigns in Gaul from 58 to 50 BC and the civil war against Pompey in 49-48 BC. Written in the third person, they combine campaign narrative with justification of Caesar's political and military conduct. They are read both as historical sources and as models of Latin prose style.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Josephus — The Jewish War; Antiquities of the Jews:** Works by Flavius Josephus, a Jewish military commander who defected to Rome during the First Jewish-Roman War. The Jewish War recounts the revolt of 66-73 AD and the destruction of the Second Temple; Antiquities of the Jews is a broader history of the Jewish people from creation to Josephus's own time. His writings are a major source for first-century Judea, including references to early Christianity.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Ammianus Marcellinus — The Later Roman Empire:** A Latin history, the Res Gestae, composed in the late 4th century AD by Ammianus Marcellinus, a former soldier, originally covering Roman history from 96 to 378 AD, of which the surviving portion covers 353-378. It includes an account of the reign of the emperor Julian, whom Ammianus had served. It is a principal narrative source for the later Roman Empire.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Arrian — The Anabasis of Alexander:** A Greek history of Alexander the Great's campaigns, written in the 2nd century AD by Arrian, a Roman provincial governor, based largely on the now-lost accounts of Alexander's officers Ptolemy and Aristobulus. It covers Alexander's campaigns from his accession through his death in 323 BC. It is generally regarded by historians as among the more reliable surviving accounts of Alexander's career.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Quintus Curtius Rufus — History of Alexander:** A Latin history of Alexander the Great, probably written in the 1st century AD, portions of which are lost. It presents a more rhetorical and moralizing account than Arrian's, with attention to the effects of success and power on Alexander's character. Its precise date and the identity of its author remain uncertain.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Diodorus Siculus — Bibliotheca Historica:** A universal history in Greek by Diodorus Siculus, written in the 1st century BC, covering mythological and historical events from the earliest times to Diodorus's own era across forty books, of which roughly a third survives intact. It draws on numerous earlier historians, some of whose works are otherwise lost. It is a significant secondary source for ancient historiography.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Strabo — Geography:** A seventeen-book Greek geographical work by Strabo, completed in the early 1st century AD, describing the physical geography, peoples, and customs of regions known to the Greco-Roman world. It combines firsthand travel observation with material drawn from earlier geographic and historical writers. It is a major source for ancient geography and ethnography.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Pausanias — Description of Greece:** A Greek work by Pausanias, written in the 2nd century AD, describing the topography, monuments, and traditions of mainland Greece region by region. It served travelers as a guide to sites of religious and historical significance. It is an important source for the identification and study of ancient Greek art and architecture.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Xenophon — Anabasis (The Persian Expedition):** A Greek prose narrative by Xenophon, an Athenian soldier and writer, describing the expedition of Greek mercenaries, the "Ten Thousand," hired by Cyrus the Younger in his bid for the Persian throne, and their retreat after Cyrus's death in battle in 401 BC. Xenophon took part in the retreat and later assumed a leadership role in it. It is considered an early example of extended first-person military narrative.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Cassius Dio — Roman History:** An eighty-book Greek history of Rome by Cassius Dio, a Roman senator active in the late 2nd and early 3rd centuries AD, covering the period from Rome's legendary founding to Dio's own lifetime. Substantial portions survive only in later summaries and excerpts. It is a significant source for the late Republic and early Empire.

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- ☐ **Velleius Paterculus — Compendium of Roman History:** A concise Latin history of Rome by Velleius Paterculus, a Roman military officer, written around 30 AD and dedicated to a consul of that year. It surveys Roman history from its origins to the reign of Tiberius, under whom Velleius had served. It is notably brief in comparison with other surviving Roman histories.

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- ☐ **Herodian — History of the Empire:** A Greek history covering the Roman Empire from the death of Marcus Aurelius in 180 AD to the accession of Gordian III in 238 AD, written by Herodian in the mid-3rd century. It covers a period marked by frequent civil war and rapid imperial succession. It is a secondary source alongside Cassius Dio and the Historia Augusta for this period.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Aulus Gellius — Attic Nights:** A Latin miscellany by Aulus Gellius, compiled in the 2nd century AD, consisting of notes on grammar, philosophy, history, and law gathered from his reading and from conversations. It is arranged in twenty books of short, loosely connected chapters. It preserves quotations and information from earlier works that would otherwise be lost.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Petronius — Satyricon:** A Latin prose work, probably by Gaius Petronius, written in the 1st century AD and surviving only in fragments, combining prose narrative with verse. Its best-preserved section, the *Cena Trimalchionis* ("Trimalchio's Feast"), depicts a lavish banquet hosted by a wealthy freedman. It is regarded as an early example of prose fiction satirizing contemporary Roman society.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Frontinus — Stratagems:** A Latin work by Sextus Julius Frontinus, a Roman general and administrator of the 1st century AD, cataloging examples of military stratagems drawn from Greek and Roman history. It is organized by category of tactic and intended as a practical supplement to his separate, now-lost treatise on military science. It was used as a reference on tactics in later periods.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Vegetius — On Military Matters (De Re Militari):** A Latin treatise on Roman military organization and training, written by Publius Flavius Vegetius Renatus, probably in the late 4th century AD. It describes recruitment, training, camp construction, and tactics, drawing on earlier military writings, with the stated aim of restoring earlier standards of discipline. It was widely copied and read as a military manual throughout the medieval period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Pliny the Younger — Letters:** A collection of Latin letters by Gaius Plinius Caecilius Secundus (Pliny the Younger), a Roman senator and official, written and compiled for publication in the late 1st and early 2nd centuries AD. They include an eyewitness account of the eruption of Vesuvius in 79 AD, which killed his uncle Pliny the Elder, and correspondence with the emperor Trajan concerning the administration of the province of Bithynia, including the treatment of Christians. They provide detailed information on the concerns of the Roman senatorial class.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Varro — On the Latin Language; On Agriculture:** Marcus Terentius Varro was a Roman scholar of the 1st century BC who wrote on a wide range of subjects. *On the Latin Language* examines etymology and grammar and survives only in part; *On Agriculture* (*Res Rusticae*) is a treatise on farming presented in dialogue form. Only a fraction of Varro's extensive output survives.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Columella — On Agriculture (De Re Rustica):** A Latin treatise on farming in twelve books by Lucius Junius Moderatus Columella, written in the 1st century AD. It covers topics including crop cultivation, livestock, viticulture, and estate management. It is among the most complete surviving Roman agricultural treatises, alongside those of Cato and Varro.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Macrobius — Saturnalia:** A Latin work by Macrobius, probably written in the early 5th century AD, structured as a dialogue set during the Roman festival of Saturnalia among a group of learned men. Its participants discuss antiquarian, literary, and philosophical topics, with substantial attention to the works of Virgil. Macrobius's Commentary on the Dream of Scipio is a related but separate work.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [ToposText](#)

Phase IV: Scripture and the Early Church

c. 1000 BC to 6th c. AD. About 201 hours of core reading.

The Hebrew Bible and the New Testament, followed by the writers who defined Christian doctrine in contact with Greek philosophy. Plotinus is placed here because Augustine read him before his conversion. Read the Psalms a few at a time across the whole phase.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. How does the God of Genesis and Exodus differ from the gods of Homer and Hesiod?
2. What question does Job ask, and is it answered?
3. What did the Fathers take from Plato, and what did they reject?
4. How does Augustine's City of God answer the fall of Rome?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **The Pentateuch (the Torah) — Genesis to Deuteronomy** (~25 h)

Read: Genesis and Exodus closely; Leviticus through Deuteronomy at a steadier pace.

Edition: Robert Alter, *The Hebrew Bible* (Norton); or any study Bible such as the New Oxford Annotated Bible (NRSV)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

2. ☐ **The Psalms** (~10 h)

Read: Spread across the phase: a few each day.

Edition: Robert Alter, *The Book of Psalms* (Norton); or a study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

3. ☐ **The Book of Job** (~5 h)

Read: The frame story, the dialogues, and the speeches from the whirlwind (38-41).

Edition: Robert Alter, *The Wisdom Books* (Norton); or a study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

4. ☐ **The Wisdom Books — Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, the Song of Songs** (~6 h)

Read: Ecclesiastes against Proverbs: the same tradition in two moods.

Edition: Robert Alter, *The Wisdom Books* (Norton); or a study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

5. ☐ **The Prophets — Isaiah and the rest** (~20 h)

Read: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Amos. Note the demand for justice and the promise of restoration.

Edition: Robert Alter, *The Hebrew Bible*, vol. 2 (Norton); or a study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

6. ☐ **The Four Gospels — Matthew, Mark, Luke, John** (~15 h)

Read: Mark first, then Matthew, Luke, and John. Note what John includes that the other three do not.

Edition: New Oxford Annotated Bible (NRSV) or the ESV Study Bible; David Bentley Hart, *The New Testament* (Yale) for a literal rendering

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

7. ☐ **The Acts of the Apostles** (~4 h)

Read: Paul's speech at Athens (17:16-34) meets Phase 2 directly.

Edition: New Oxford Annotated Bible (NRSV) or another study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

8. ☐ **The Pauline Epistles** (~10 h)

Read: Romans, 1 Corinthians (chapters 13 and 15), Galatians, Philippians.

Edition: New Oxford Annotated Bible (NRSV) or another study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

9. ☐ **The Apocalypse (Revelation)** (~3 h)

Read: Read after Daniel if possible; the imagery draws on it.

Edition: New Oxford Annotated Bible (NRSV) or another study Bible

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

10. ☐ **The Didache** (~1 h)

Read: The earliest surviving church manual: the Two Ways, baptism, the Eucharist.

Edition: In Early Christian Writings: The Apostolic Fathers, tr. Staniforth and Louth (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

11. ☐ **St. Ignatius of Antioch — The Letters** (~2 h)

Read: The Letter to the Romans, written on the way to his execution.

Edition: In Early Christian Writings: The Apostolic Fathers (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

12. ☐ **St. Justin Martyr — The First and Second Apologies** (~4 h)

Read: The First Apology and its idea of the logos spermatikos in pagan philosophy.

Edition: Tr. Leslie William Barnard, The First and Second Apologies (Paulist, Ancient Christian Writers)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

13. ☐ **St. Irenaeus — Against Heresies** (~12 h)

Read: Book I on the Gnostic systems, then Books III-IV on apostolic tradition and recapitulation.

Edition: Ante-Nicene Fathers vol. 1 (free at New Advent); or Robert M. Grant, Irenaeus of Lyons (Routledge) for selections

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

14. ☐ **St. Athanasius — On the Incarnation; The Life of Antony** (~6 h)

Read: On the Incarnation in full; The Life of Antony founded the genre of the desert saint.

Edition: On the Incarnation, tr. John Behr (St Vladimir's Seminary Press); The Life of Antony, tr. Robert C. Gregg (Paulist)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

15. ☐ **Plotinus — The Enneads** (~20 h)

Read: I.6 (On Beauty), V.1, and VI.9 (On the Good or the One). These are the 'books of the Platonists' Augustine mentions in Confessions VII.

Edition: Tr. Stephen MacKenna, abridged by John Dillon (Penguin); or the Gerson edition (Cambridge)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Perseus Greco-Roman](#) · [MIT Internet Classics Archive](#) · [ToposText](#)

16. ☐ **St. Augustine — Confessions** (~12 h)

Read: Books I-IX narrative, X on memory, XI on time.

Edition: Tr. Henry Chadwick (Oxford World's Classics) or Sarah Ruden (Modern Library)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

17. ☐ **St. Augustine — The City of God; On Christian Doctrine; On the Trinity** (~40 h)

Read: City of God I-V, XI-XIV, XIX. On Christian Doctrine Book II for how the tradition read texts.

Edition: City of God tr. Henry Bettenson (Penguin); On Christian Doctrine tr. R.P.H. Green (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

18. ☐ **St. Benedict of Nursia — The Rule** (~3 h)

Read: The Prologue and chapters on obedience, humility (7), and daily order. It governed Western monasticism.

Edition: RB 1980: The Rule of St. Benedict, ed. Timothy Fry (Liturgical Press)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

19. ☐ **Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite — The Celestial Hierarchy; The Mystical Theology** (~3 h)

Read: The Mystical Theology is very short: the source of the negative way used in Phases 5 and 8.

Edition: Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works, tr. Colm Luibheid (Paulist, Classics of Western Spirituality)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

Synthesis. Write on Augustine as the meeting point of Phase 2 (Plato and Plotinus), Phase 3 (Rome and Cicero), and Scripture.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **St. Jerome (trans.) — The Vulgate:** A Latin translation of the Bible produced largely by Jerome in the late 4th and early 5th centuries AD, translating the Old Testament directly from Hebrew and revising existing Latin translations of the New Testament. It became the standard biblical text of the Western Church for centuries and was affirmed as authoritative by the Council of Trent in 1546.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Septuagint:** A Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures produced in stages beginning in the 3rd century BC, primarily in Alexandria. It was widely used by Greek-speaking Jewish communities and by early Christians, and it is frequently quoted in the New Testament. It also includes several books not present in the later Hebrew canon.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Deuterocanon — Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach, and the rest:** A group of texts included in the Septuagint and the Latin Vulgate but excluded from the Hebrew Bible and, subsequently, from most Protestant biblical canons following the Reformation. They include the Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach, Tobit, Judith, and 1-2 Maccabees, among others, composed mostly between the 3rd and 1st centuries BC. Catholic and Orthodox traditions regard them as canonical scripture, while Protestant traditions generally classify them as apocrypha.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Gallican / Roman Psalter:** Latin versions of the Book of Psalms arranged for liturgical recitation in the Western Church. The Gallican Psalter, based on Jerome's revision from the Greek Septuagint, became the version most widely used in medieval monastic worship. These arrangements structured the recitation of the Psalms across a weekly or other fixed cycle in monastic communities.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Roman Breviary (the Divine Office):** The liturgical book containing the texts for the Liturgy of the Hours, the cycle of prayers, psalms, and readings recited by clergy and religious at fixed times throughout the day. Its structure developed over centuries from early Christian and monastic practice, with the Roman Breviary standardized in its modern form after the Council of Trent. Its use remains obligatory for clergy in the Catholic Church, in updated forms following the Second Vatican Council.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Roman Missal:** The liturgical book containing the texts and rubrics for the celebration of the Mass in the Roman Rite of the Catholic Church. Its contents developed over many centuries, with major standardized editions issued after the Council of Trent (1570) and following the Second Vatican Council (1970). It includes prayers, scripture-reading assignments, and instructions for the liturgical calendar.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Roman Martyrology:** The official liturgical martyrology of the Catholic Church, listing saints and martyrs commemorated on each day of the calendar year, along with brief biographical notices. Its current form developed from earlier martyrologies and was revised several times, most recently in 2001 and 2004. It is used in monastic and clerical communities for daily recitation.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Catholic Epistles — James, Peter, John, Jude:** A group of New Testament letters — James, 1-2 Peter, 1-3 John, and Jude — traditionally described as "catholic" or "general" because they are addressed to broader Christian audiences rather than to specific individual churches. They cover topics including ethical conduct, perseverance under persecution, and warnings against false teaching. Their dates of composition and authorship are debated among scholars.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Book of Daniel:** A book of the Hebrew Bible combining narrative and apocalyptic visions, set during the Babylonian and Persian periods but generally dated by modern scholars to the 2nd century BC in its final form. It includes stories such as Daniel in the lions' den and the three men in the fiery furnace, alongside symbolic visions of successive empires. It contributed imagery, including the phrase "Son of Man," later taken up in the New Testament.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **The Divine Liturgy of St. John Chrysostom:** The most commonly used eucharistic liturgy in the Eastern Orthodox Church, traditionally attributed to St. John Chrysostom (c. 349-407 AD), though its present form developed over subsequent centuries. It structures the celebration of the Eucharist with a fixed sequence of prayers, litanies, and hymns. It is used on most days of the liturgical year outside of specific fasting periods.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Bible Gateway](#)

- ☐ **St. Gregory the Great — Pastoral Care (Liber Regulae Pastoralis):** A treatise written around 590-591 AD by Pope Gregory I, addressing the responsibilities and conduct expected of bishops and other pastors. It discusses how spiritual guidance should be adapted to different types of people and circumstances. It was translated into Old English under King Alfred the Great in the 9th century for distribution to English bishops.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Aldhelm — In Praise of Virginité (De Virginitate):** A work by the Anglo-Saxon scholar and bishop Aldhelm (c. 639-709 AD), composed in both prose and verse versions, addressing the theme of religious virginity and chastity. It is written in an elaborate, Latinate style characteristic of Aldhelm's works. It is among the earliest substantial Latin literary works produced in Anglo-Saxon England.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Clement of Rome — The First Epistle to the Corinthians:** A letter, likely written in the late 1st century AD, sent from the Christian community in Rome to the church at Corinth to address a leadership dispute there. It is among the earliest surviving Christian texts outside the New Testament and references the authority of church leadership established through apostolic succession. It was read as scripture in some early Christian communities, though it was not included in the eventual New Testament canon.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Tertullian — Apology:** A work written around 197 AD by the North African writer Tertullian, defending Christians against Roman legal persecution and popular accusations. Tertullian is credited with significant contributions to Latin Christian theological vocabulary. He later associated with the Montanist movement, considered heterodox by the broader Church.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Clement of Alexandria — The Stromata; The Tutor:** Works by the 2nd-3rd century AD theologian Clement of Alexandria, who taught at the catechetical school in Alexandria. The Stromata ("Miscellanies") discusses the relationship between Greek philosophy and Christian faith; The Tutor (Paedagogus) addresses Christian ethical conduct. Clement argued that philosophy could serve as a preparation for Christian belief.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Origen — On First Principles:** A systematic theological work by the 3rd-century AD scholar Origen of Alexandria, one of the earliest attempts at a comprehensive Christian theology. It addresses topics including the nature of God, creation, free will, and the eventual state of all rational beings. Some of Origen's speculative positions were later condemned as heterodox by church councils, though his broader influence on Christian theology and biblical scholarship was substantial.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Eusebius — Ecclesiastical History:** A history of the Christian Church from its origins to the early 4th century AD, written by Eusebius of Caesarea and completed in stages, with a final edition after 324 AD. It preserves excerpts from earlier documents, many otherwise lost, including accounts of persecutions and martyrdoms. It is a primary source for the history of early Christianity.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Hilary of Poitiers — On the Trinity:** A theological work by Hilary, bishop of Poitiers (c. 310-367 AD), written partly during his exile under the Arian-sympathizing emperor Constantius II. It defends the doctrine of the full divinity of Christ against Arian positions that held the Son to be a created, subordinate being. It is among the earliest major Latin treatments of Trinitarian theology.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Basil the Great — On the Holy Spirit; Hexaemeron; To Young Men:** Works by Basil of Caesarea (c. 330-379 AD), one of the three Cappadocian Fathers. On the Holy Spirit argues for the divinity of the Holy Spirit; the Hexaemeron is a series of homilies on the six days of creation; To Young Men advises Christian students on how to make selective use of classical Greek literature. Basil also contributed to the organization of communal monastic life in the Eastern Church.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Gregory of Nazianzus — The Theological Orations:** Five orations delivered by Gregory of Nazianzus (c. 329-390 AD) in Constantinople around 380 AD, addressing Trinitarian theology, particularly the divinity of the Son and the Holy Spirit. Gregory, another of the Cappadocian Fathers, is traditionally given the title "the Theologian" in the Eastern Church. The orations were influential in the doctrinal settlement affirmed at the First Council of Constantinople in 381.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Gregory of Nyssa — The Life of Moses; On the Soul and the Resurrection:** Works by Gregory of Nyssa (c. 335-395 AD), the third of the Cappadocian Fathers. The Life of Moses interprets the biblical account of Moses allegorically as a model of spiritual progress toward God. On the Soul and the Resurrection, structured as a dialogue, discusses the nature of the soul and Christian teaching on resurrection; Gregory developed the concept of *epektasis*, describing spiritual growth as an unending process.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. John Chrysostom — On the Priesthood; the Homilies:** Works by John Chrysostom (c. 347-407 AD), archbishop of Constantinople, known for his skill as a preacher. On the Priesthood discusses the responsibilities and challenges of pastoral ministry. His numerous surviving homilies offer verse-by-verse scriptural commentary along with moral exhortation, including attention to care for the poor.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Ambrose — On the Duties of the Clergy; Hexameron:** Works by Ambrose, bishop of Milan (c. 340-397 AD), a former Roman governor. On the Duties of the Clergy (*De Officiis*) adapts Cicero's philosophical treatment of ethical duty to a Christian clerical context. Ambrose is known for instructing Augustine of Hippo prior to Augustine's conversion and for requiring the emperor Theodosius I to perform public penance following a massacre at Thessalonica.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Jerome — Letters; On Illustrious Men:** Writings of Jerome (c. 342-420 AD), the scholar-monk best known for translating the Vulgate Bible (see Book 15). His surviving letters address scriptural, ascetic, and controversial topics. On Illustrious Men is a biographical catalog of Christian authors up to Jerome's own time, modeled on earlier Roman biographical works.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. John Cassian — Conferences; Institutes:** Works by John Cassian (c. 360-435 AD), who transmitted the monastic practices of the Egyptian desert to the Latin-speaking West. The Conferences record discussions attributed to Egyptian monastic teachers on topics including prayer and spiritual discernment. The Institutes addresses the organization of monastic communities and discusses eight principal vices; both works influenced the later Rule of St. Benedict.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Cyprian — On the Unity of the Church:** A treatise written around 251 AD by Cyprian, bishop of Carthage, addressing a schism within the North African church. It argues for the unity of the Church under the collective authority of its bishops. Cyprian was executed during the persecution under the emperor Valerian in 258 AD.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Lactantius — The Divine Institutes:** A work by the early 4th-century Christian writer Lactantius, presenting Christian doctrine in classical Latin prose style for an educated Roman readership. It critiques polytheistic religion and presents Christianity as compatible with, and superior to, classical philosophical ethics. Lactantius later served as tutor to Crispus, son of the emperor Constantine.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Leo the Great — The Tome; the Sermons:** Writings of Pope Leo I (r. 440-461 AD). The Tome of Leo, a letter addressing the theological dispute over the nature of Christ, was influential at the Council of Chalcedon in 451, which affirmed that Christ has two natures, divine and human, in one person. His surviving sermons address doctrinal and liturgical topics; Leo is also noted for meeting Attila the Hun in 452, traditionally credited with persuading him not to advance on Rome.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Gregory the Great — Dialogues; Moralia in Job:** Works by Pope Gregory I (r. 590-604 AD), also known for the Pastoral Care (above) and for sending missionaries to convert Anglo-Saxon England. The Dialogues recount lives and miracles of Italian saints, including Benedict of Nursia. The Moralia in Job is an extended allegorical and moral commentary on the Book of Job.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Cassiodorus — Institutions of Divine and Secular Learning:** A work by the Roman statesman Cassiodorus (c. 485-585 AD), written after he founded the monastery of Vivarium in southern Italy. The Institutions outlines a curriculum combining the study of scripture with the classical liberal arts, intended to guide the monastery's work of copying manuscripts. The monastery's copying activity contributed to the preservation of a number of classical texts.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Maximus the Confessor — The Ambigua; Centuries on Love:** Works by the Byzantine monk and theologian Maximus the Confessor (c. 580-662 AD). The Ambigua addresses difficult passages in earlier theological writers, particularly Gregory of Nazianzus. Maximus opposed the Monothelite position that Christ had only a divine will, and he was mutilated and exiled for this opposition; his theological positions were later vindicated at the Third Council of Constantinople in 680-681.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. John of Damascus — On the Orthodox Faith:** A theological work by John of Damascus (c. 675-749 AD), part of his larger Fount of Knowledge, summarizing earlier Greek patristic theology into a systematic exposition. John also wrote in defense of the use of religious images during the Byzantine Iconoclast controversy, arguing that the Incarnation justified depicting Christ. He is traditionally regarded as the last of the major Greek Church Fathers.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **The Shepherd of Hermas:** An early Christian text, likely composed in Rome during the 1st or 2nd century AD, presented as a series of visions, mandates, and parables concerning repentance and church discipline. It was widely read in the early Church, and some early sources considered it for inclusion in the New Testament canon, though it was ultimately excluded.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Ephrem the Syrian — The Hymns on Paradise and the Nativity:** Hymns composed by Ephrem the Syrian (c. 306-373 AD), a deacon and theologian who wrote in Syriac. The Hymns on Paradise use imagery to explore biblical and theological themes concerning creation and paradise; the Nativity hymns address the birth of Christ. Ephrem's poetic hymns were used for both liturgical and catechetical purposes in the Syriac Christian tradition.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Vincent of Lerins — The Commonitory:** A treatise written around 434 AD by Vincent, a monk at the monastery of Lerins, proposing criteria for distinguishing authentic Christian doctrine from heresy. It is known for articulating the standard of belief "held everywhere, always, and by all" (*quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus*). It addresses the concept of legitimate doctrinal development within continuity of tradition.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [New Advent: Fathers](#) · [CCEL](#)

Phase V: The Middle Ages

6th to 15th c.. About 232 hours of core reading.

Three strands interleaved: the northern heroic literature (Anglo-Saxon, Norse, Celtic), the theology of the schools and cloisters, and the romance and epic that culminated in Dante and Chaucer. Boethius opens the phase because every medieval writer knew him.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. How does the heroic code of Beowulf and the sagas change once Christianity arrives?
2. What is scholastic method, and why does Aquinas write in questions and objections?
3. How does courtly love in the romances relate to love of God in the mystics?
4. What does Dante's structure (three realms, 100 cantos) say about his view of order?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **St. Boethius — The Consolation of Philosophy** (~6 h)

Read: Written in prison awaiting execution. Book II on Fortune's wheel, Book V on providence and free will.

Edition: Tr. P.G. Walsh (Oxford World's Classics) or Joel Relihan (Hackett)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

2. ☐ **St. Bede — Ecclesiastical History of the English People** (~12 h)

Read: Book II.13 (the sparrow in the hall) and IV.24 (Caedmon).

Edition: Tr. Leo Sherley-Price, rev. Farmer (Penguin); or Colgrave and McClure (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

3. ☐ **Anon. — Beowulf** (~5 h)

Read: The poem's three fights and its Christian narrator commenting on a pagan past.

Edition: Tr. Seamus Heaney (Norton); or Roy Liuzza (Broadview), with notes

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

4. ☐ **The Anglo-Saxon Elegies — The Wanderer; The Seafarer; The Dream of the Rood; The Battle of Maldon** (~2 h)

Read: The Wanderer and The Seafarer first; The Dream of the Rood recasts the Crucifixion in heroic diction.

Edition: In *The Word Exchange: Anglo-Saxon Poems in Translation*, ed. Delanty and Matto (Norton); or Kevin Crossley-Holland, *The Anglo-Saxon World* (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

5. ☐ **The Poetic Edda** (~10 h)

Read: Voluspa (the creation and end of the world) and Havamal (the sayings of Odin), then the heroic poems.

Edition: Tr. Carolyne Larrington (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

6. ☐ **Njal's Saga; Egil's Saga; Laxdaela Saga** (~15 h)

Read: Njal's Saga first. Law, feud, and the conversion of Iceland.

Edition: Njal's Saga tr. Robert Cook (Penguin); *The Sagas of Icelanders*, ed. Ornlöf Thorsson (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

7. ☐ **Tain Bo Cuailnge (The Cattle Raid of Cooley)** (~8 h)

Read: Cu Chulainn's defense of Ulster; the central epic of the Ulster Cycle.

Edition: Tr. Thomas Kinsella, *The Tain* (Oxford); or Ciaran Carson (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
8. ☐ **The Mabinogion** (~8 h)

Read: The Four Branches first, then Culhwch and Olwen for the earliest Arthur.

Edition: Tr. Sioned Davies (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
9. ☐ **The Song of Roland** (~4 h)

Read: Compare Roland's pride with Achilles'. Oliver is the counterweight.

Edition: Tr. Glyn Burgess (Penguin) or Dorothy L. Sayers (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
10. ☐ **St. Anselm — Proslogion; Monologion; Cur Deus Homo** (~5 h)

Read: Proslogion 2-4 (the ontological argument) and Cur Deus Homo.

Edition: Anselm of Canterbury: The Major Works, ed. Davies and Evans (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
11. ☐ **Peter Abelard — Sic et Non; Historia Calamitatum** (~4 h)

Read: Historia Calamitatum; the prologue to Sic et Non sets out the method of reconciling authorities.

Edition: The Letters of Abelard and Heloise, tr. Betty Radice, rev. Clanchy (Penguin), includes Historia Calamitatum

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
12. ☐ **St. Bernard of Clairvaux — On Loving God; Sermons on the Song of Songs** (~5 h)

Read: On Loving God: the four degrees of love.

Edition: Bernard of Clairvaux: Selected Works, tr. G.R. Evans (Paulist, Classics of Western Spirituality)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
13. ☐ **Chretien de Troyes — Perceval; Lancelot; Yvain; Erec and Enide** (~12 h)

Read: Yvain and Lancelot, then Perceval, the first Grail story.

Edition: Tr. William W. Kibler and Carleton W. Carroll, *Arthurian Romances* (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
14. ☐ **Anon. — Sir Gawain and the Green Knight** (~4 h)

Read: The three temptations and the three blows.

Edition: Tr. Simon Armitage (Norton) or J.R.R. Tolkien (Del Rey / HarperCollins)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
15. ☐ **St. Thomas Aquinas — Summa Theologiae; Summa contra Gentiles; On Kingship** (~40 h)

Read: Summa Theologiae I qq.1-13 (God, including the five ways in q.2), I-II qq.90-97 (law), selections on the virtues in II-II; On Kingship.

Edition: Summa Theologiae: A Concise Translation, ed. Timothy McDermott (Christian Classics); On Law, Morality, and Politics, ed. Regan and Baumgarth (Hackett); full Dominican Fathers translation free at New Advent

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
16. ☐ **St. Bonaventure — The Journey of the Mind to God** (~3 h)

Read: A short itinerary of the mind's ascent in six stages, set against Aquinas.

Edition: Bonaventure: The Soul's Journey into God, tr. Ewert Cousins (Paulist); or tr. Philotheus Boehner (Franciscan Institute)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

17. ☐ **Dante Alighieri — The Divine Comedy; De Monarchia** (~30 h)

Read: The Divine Comedy in order. Many readers stop after Inferno; Purgatorio and Paradiso are where the argument resolves.

Edition: Tr. Robert and Jean Hollander (Anchor, facing Italian with notes); or John Ciardi (Signet); or Allen Mandelbaum (Everyman)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

18. ☐ **Geoffrey Chaucer — The Canterbury Tales; Troilus and Criseyde** (~20 h)

Read: The General Prologue, then the Knight's, Miller's, Wife of Bath's, Pardoner's, and Nun's Priest's Tales.

Edition: Middle English: The Riverside Chaucer (Oxford) or the Norton Critical Edition; modern English tr. Nevill Coghill (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

19. ☐ **Anon. — The Cloud of Unknowing** (~4 h)

Read: The negative way from Pseudo-Dionysius put into English practice.

Edition: Tr. A.C. Spearing (Penguin); or ed. James Walsh (Paulist)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

20. ☐ **Julian of Norwich — Revelations of Divine Love** (~5 h)

Read: The first woman known to have written a book in English. The parable of the lord and the servant (ch. 51).

Edition: Tr. Elizabeth Spearing (Penguin); or Colledge and Walsh (Paulist)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

21. ☐ **Sir Thomas Malory — Le Morte d'Arthur** (~25 h)

Read: The Tale of the Sankgreal and the last two tales: the fall of the Round Table.

Edition: Ed. Stephen H.A. Shepherd (Norton Critical Edition); or Helen Cooper's abridgment (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

22. ☐ **Thomas a Kempis — The Imitation of Christ** (~5 h)

Read: Books I-II. It closes the phase as the late-medieval devotional handbook.

Edition: Tr. Leo Sherley-Price (Penguin); or William Creasy (Ave Maria Press)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

Synthesis. Compare a Germanic hero (Beowulf or Njal) with a romance knight (Gawain or Lancelot) and with Dante the pilgrim.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Snorri Sturluson — The Prose Edda; Heimskringla:** Works by the thirteenth-century Icelandic chieftain and writer Snorri Sturluson. The Prose Edda is a handbook of Norse mythology and poetic technique, intended to preserve knowledge needed to compose traditional skaldic verse; Heimskringla is a history of the kings of Norway from legendary origins to the twelfth century.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Nibelungenlied:** An anonymous Middle High German epic poem, composed around 1200, telling of the hero Siegfried, his murder, and the subsequent revenge taken by his widow Kriemhild against her own kin. It draws on earlier Germanic legend and later influenced works including Richard Wagner's Ring cycle.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Saga of the Volsungs:** An Old Norse prose saga, composed around the thirteenth century, retelling the legend of the Volsung and Niflung families, including the hero Sigurd, the cursed treasure of the dragon Fafnir, and the downfall of the Burgundian kings. It parallels, and shares sources with, the Nibelungenlied.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Caedmon's Hymn:** A short Old English poem of nine lines praising God as creator, attributed by Bede to the herdsman Caedmon in the seventh century. Bede's account describes Caedmon receiving the ability to compose religious verse in a vision. It is among the earliest attested pieces of English poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Kalevala:** A Finnish epic compiled by Elias Lonnrot in the nineteenth century from Karelian and Finnish oral folk poetry, centering on the wizard-hero Vainamoinen and a magical artifact called the Sampo. It is regarded as the Finnish national epic and influenced later works, including music by Jean Sibelius.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Grettir's Saga (The Saga of Grettir the Strong):** An Icelandic saga composed in the fourteenth century, recounting the life of the outlaw Grettir Asmundarson, including his fights against supernatural adversaries and his years as a fugitive. It is one of the later works in the Icelanders' sagas tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Vinland Sagas (The Greenlanders' Saga; Erik the Red's Saga):** Two Icelandic sagas describing Norse voyages from Greenland to North America around 1000 AD. They are considered, alongside archaeological evidence at L'Anse aux Meadows, historical sources for pre-Columbian Norse contact with North America.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Hervarar Saga (The Saga of King Heidrek the Wise):** A legendary Icelandic saga incorporating older heroic poetry, centering on a cursed sword named Tyrfing and including a section of riddle contests between King Heidrek and Odin in disguise. J.R.R. Tolkien, who edited and translated the saga, drew on its riddle contest when writing The Hobbit.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Widsith; Deor:** Two short Old English poems preserved in the Exeter Book. Widsith presents itself as the catalog of peoples and rulers visited by a legendary wandering minstrel; Deor is spoken by a poet recounting past misfortunes, each followed by the refrain "that passed away, so may this."
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Poem of the Cid:** A Spanish epic poem probably composed in the mid-12th century, recounting the campaigns of Rodrigo Diaz de Vivar, known as El Cid, after his exile by King Alfonso VI of Castile. It describes his military successes, including the conquest of Valencia, and his eventual reconciliation with the king. It is one of the earliest and best-preserved works of medieval Spanish literature.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Wolfram von Eschenbach — Parzival:** A Middle High German verse romance composed in the early 13th century, adapting and extending Chretien de Troyes's unfinished Perceval. It follows the knight Parzival from naive youth through failure to his eventual attainment of the Grail. It later served as the primary literary source for Richard Wagner's opera Parsifal.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Gottfried von Strassburg — Tristan:** An unfinished Middle High German verse romance from the early 13th century, retelling the legend of Tristan and Isolde. It centers on the love potion that binds the two despite Isolde's marriage to King Mark of Cornwall. It is one of the principal medieval German treatments of the Tristan story.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Anon. — The Quest of the Holy Grail:** A 13th-century French prose romance, part of the Vulgate (Lancelot-Grail) Cycle, concerning the Arthurian knights' pursuit of the Holy Grail. It emphasizes spiritual purity, and only Galahad, Percival, and Bors are shown achieving the Grail. It recasts the earlier chivalric romance tradition in explicitly religious terms.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Giovanni Boccaccio — The Decameron:** A collection of 100 novellas in Italian prose, written around 1349-1353, framed as stories told by ten young Florentines sheltering outside the city during the Black Death. The tales range across comic, tragic, and erotic subjects drawn from varied sources. It influenced later European prose fiction, including Chaucer.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Guillaume de Lorris & Jean de Meun — The Romance of the Rose:** A French allegorical poem in two parts. The first, by Guillaume de Lorris (c. 1230), presents a dream-vision of the pursuit of courtly love, personified as a rose; the second, by Jean de Meun (c. 1275), adds extensive philosophical, satirical, and encyclopedic digressions. It was widely read across medieval Europe and partly translated into English, in a version once attributed to Chaucer.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Ludovico Ariosto — Orlando Furioso:** An Italian epic poem first published in 1516 and completed in its final form in 1532, continuing the narrative begun in Boiardo's Orlando Innamorato. It follows the knight Orlando's madness brought on by unrequited love for Angelica, alongside numerous interwoven episodes involving Charlemagne's paladins and their Saracen adversaries. It is written in ottava rima.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Torquato Tasso — Jerusalem Delivered:** An Italian epic poem published in 1581, presenting a fictionalized account of the First Crusade and the 1099 siege of Jerusalem. It combines historical military narrative with episodes of romance and supernatural enchantment. It is considered a major work of the later Italian Renaissance epic tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Edmund Spenser — The Faerie Queene:** An English allegorical epic poem; its first three books were published in 1590 and further books in 1596, with the work left unfinished at Spenser's death. Each completed book follows a knight representing a particular virtue in service to the Faerie Queene, a figure generally understood to represent Queen Elizabeth I. It is written in a nine-line stanza form now called the Spenserian stanza.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Jean Froissart — Chronicles:** A French-language chronicle covering events in Western Europe, chiefly during the Hundred Years' War, from the 1320s into the early 15th century. Froissart drew on eyewitness testimony and his own travels among the nobility of England, France, and the Low Countries. The Chronicles are a major narrative source for the political and military history of the period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Francois Villon — The Testament:** A poem written in 1461 by Francois Villon, a French poet whose recorded life included periods of crime and imprisonment. Framed as a mock last will and testament, it addresses mortality, poverty, and the passage of time, combining formal ballades with satirical and autobiographical passages. It is among the best-known works of later medieval French poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Marie de France — The Lais:** A collection of twelve narrative poems in Old French, composed in the late 12th century by a poet identified only as Marie, believed to have been active at the English court. The lais are short verse tales concerning love, often incorporating supernatural or Breton folkloric elements. Marie de France is one of the few named women writers of the medieval period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Beroul & Thomas — The Romance of Tristan:** Two separate 12th-century Old French verse versions of the Tristan and Isolde legend, attributed respectively to Beroul and to a poet known as Thomas of Britain, both surviving only in fragments. They are among the earliest literary treatments of the Tristan story. They were drawn on by later versions, including Gottfried von Strassburg's Tristan.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Amadis of Gaul:** A prose chivalric romance of Iberian origin, published in its best-known Spanish form by Garci Rodriguez de Montalvo in 1508, though earlier versions likely circulated before then. It follows the adventures of the knight Amadis and was widely popular across 16th-century Europe. It is referenced in Cervantes's Don Quixote as one of the chivalric romances read by the protagonist.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Aucassin et Nicolette:** An anonymous French work of the late 12th or early 13th century, combining alternating passages of sung verse and spoken prose, a form known as a *chanteable*. It tells of the love between the nobleman Aucassin and Nicolette, an enslaved woman, and includes elements parodying conventions of contemporary romance. It survives in a single manuscript.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Lebor Gabala Erenn (The Book of Invasions):** A medieval Irish compilation of prose and verse, surviving in several recensions from around the 11th century onward, presenting a pseudo-historical account of Ireland's successive legendary settlements. It traces the ancestry of the Irish to the Gaels, described as the last of the invading peoples to arrive. It combines native mythological material with elements adapted from biblical and classical history.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Ulster Cycle — Bricriu's Feast; The Destruction of Da Derga's Hostel; The Wooing of Etain:** A group of early Irish narratives centered on the warriors of King Conchobar mac Nessa and the hero Cu Chulainn. Bricriu's Feast concerns a contest over a champion's portion at a feast; The Destruction of Da Derga's Hostel recounts the death of King Conaire; The Wooing of Etain involves the otherworldly figure Midir. They survive chiefly in medieval manuscripts such as the Book of the Dun Cow.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Mythological Cycle — Cath Maige Tuired:** A body of early Irish narrative concerning the Tuatha De Danann, a supernatural race said to have inhabited Ireland before the arrival of the Gaels. Cath Maige Tuired recounts their conflict with the Fomorians for control of Ireland. It survives in medieval manuscripts reflecting older traditional material.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Fenian Cycle — Acallam na Senorach; The Pursuit of Diarmuid and Grainne:** A body of early Irish literature centered on the warrior Finn mac Cumhaill and his band, the Fianna. Acallam na Senorach, composed around the 12th century, frames surviving members of the Fianna recounting earlier tales to St. Patrick. The Pursuit of Diarmuid and Grainne tells of the elopement of Grainne, betrothed to Finn, with the warrior Diarmuid.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Immrama — The Voyage of Bran; The Voyage of Mael Duin:** Early Irish narratives belonging to the immram, or "voyage," genre, describing sea journeys to supernatural otherworld islands. The Voyage of Bran dates to around the 8th century; the Voyage of Mael Duin is somewhat later and combines pre-Christian and Christian elements. They are among the earliest surviving examples of the genre.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Annals of the Four Masters; The Annals of Ulster:** Chronological compilations of Irish history. The Annals of the Four Masters were compiled in the 17th century from earlier sources, covering events from legendary antiquity to 1616. The Annals of Ulster cover a comparable span and were compiled from the 15th century onward using earlier annalistic material.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Senchas Mar (the Brehon law tracts):** A collection of early Irish legal texts, compiled around the 8th century, forming part of the native Irish body of customary law known as Brehon law. It addresses areas including contract, status, and compensation, administered through mechanisms distinct from later feudal or common law systems. It is among the earliest vernacular law codes recorded in Europe.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Lebor na hUidre; The Book of Leinster:** Two principal medieval Irish manuscripts. Lebor na hUidre ("Book of the Dun Cow"), compiled around 1100, is the oldest surviving manuscript written wholly in Irish. The Book of Leinster dates from the 12th century. Both preserve texts of the Ulster Cycle and other early Irish literature, copied by monastic scribes.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Welsh Triads (Trioedd Ynys Prydein):** A collection of medieval Welsh texts organizing traditional lore into groups of three related figures or events, used as a mnemonic device by poets and storytellers. The triads reference people and episodes from Welsh legend, including material connected to Arthur. They survive in manuscripts from the 13th century onward, though the underlying material is older.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Aneirin — Y Gododdin:** An early Welsh poem attributed to the poet Aneirin, commemorating warriors of the Gododdin kingdom killed at the Battle of Catraeth, traditionally dated to around 600 AD. It survives in a 13th-century manuscript known as the Book of Aneirin. It contains a passage sometimes cited as the earliest surviving reference to Arthur.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Book of Taliesin:** A 14th-century Welsh manuscript containing poems attributed to the 6th-century bard Taliesin, though scholars date much of the material to later centuries. The collection includes praise poetry alongside poems with mythological and riddling content, some employing a shape-shifting first-person voice. It is a primary source for early Welsh bardic poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Black Book of Carmarthen:** A Welsh manuscript dating to around the mid-13th century, considered the earliest surviving manuscript written wholly in Welsh. It contains varied early poetry, including material referencing Arthur and Myrddin, the figure later associated with Merlin. It is held at the National Library of Wales.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Red Book of Hergest:** A large Welsh manuscript compiled in the late 14th or early 15th century, containing prose tales including the Mabinogion along with extensive poetry. It is one of the principal manuscript sources for medieval Welsh literature. It is held at the Bodleian Library, Oxford.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **St. Patrick — Confessio; Letter to Coroticus:** Two Latin texts generally accepted as the authentic writings of St. Patrick, the missionary credited with a central role in Ireland's conversion to Christianity, probably written in the 5th century. The Confessio is autobiographical, describing his capture and enslavement in Ireland, his escape, and his return as a missionary. The Letter to Coroticus condemns a raid by a British warlord against Patrick's converts.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Adomnan of Iona — The Life of St. Columba:** A Latin hagiography written around 700 AD by Adomnan, abbot of Iona, recounting the life of St. Columba, the 6th-century Irish monk who founded the monastery of Iona and is associated with the conversion of parts of Scotland. It is organized around prophecies, miracles, and visions attributed to Columba. It also provides incidental information on early monastic life.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Voyage of St. Brendan (Navigatio Sancti Brendani):** A Latin narrative, probably composed in the 9th or 10th century, recounting a legendary sea voyage by the Irish abbot St. Brendan in search of a paradise called the Promised Land of the Saints. It combines the earlier immram genre with explicitly Christian pilgrimage themes. It circulated widely in medieval Europe in numerous translations.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Nennius — Historia Brittonum:** A Latin compilation of British history and legend traditionally attributed to Nennius, dating to around the early 9th century. It is among the earliest sources to mention Arthur, listing twelve battles he is said to have fought against Saxon invaders. It combines genealogical, chronological, and legendary material.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Buile Suibhne (The Frenzy of Sweeney):** A medieval Irish prose and verse narrative, surviving in a manuscript of around the 17th century though reflecting an older story, telling of King Suibhne, who is cursed with madness and transformed into a bird-like wanderer after a battle. The text combines narrative prose with lyric verse attributed to Suibhne during his exile. It has been the subject of modern translations and adaptations, including by Seamus Heaney and Flann O'Brien.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Early Irish Nature Lyrics (incl. "Pangur Ban"):** A body of short lyric poems composed by monastic scribes in medieval Ireland, often recorded in manuscript margins, addressing subjects such as hermit life, the natural world, and the seasons. "Pangur Ban," probably composed in the 8th or 9th century, compares the poet's pursuit of scholarship to his cat's pursuit of mice. These poems are noted for their concision and personal tone.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Sanas Cormaic (Cormac's Glossary):** An early Irish glossary traditionally attributed to Cormac mac Cuilennain, bishop-king of Munster, compiled around the 9th or 10th century. It explains Irish words through etymology, some accurate and some fanciful, along with associated lore and legend. It is considered an early example of a vernacular etymological dictionary in Europe.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Dafydd ap Gwilym — Poems:** A Welsh poet active in the 14th century whose surviving corpus consists mainly of love poetry and poems addressing the natural world. He combined traditional Welsh bardic meters, particularly the cywydd form, with themes associated with continental courtly love poetry. He is considered a major poet of medieval Wales.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Orosius — History Against the Pagans:** A Latin work by Paulus Orosius, written around 417-418 AD at the encouragement of Augustine of Hippo, presenting a universal history intended to argue that pre-Christian history included calamities comparable to those following Rome's decline. It was written partly in response to claims that Christianity was responsible for the sack of Rome in 410. It was widely used as a standard historical reference throughout the Middle Ages.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Gregory of Tours — The History of the Franks:** A Latin chronicle by Gregory, bishop of Tours, written in the late 6th century, covering the history of the Frankish kingdoms under the Merovingian dynasty, with particular attention to Gregory's own time. It combines political narrative with ecclesiastical material and accounts of miracles. It is a principal source for Merovingian Gaul.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Einhard — The Life of Charlemagne:** A Latin biography of the emperor Charlemagne written by Einhard, a member of his court, in the 820s or 830s, modeled explicitly on Suetonius's Lives of the Caesars. It covers Charlemagne's conquests, administration, and personal habits and appearance. It is a principal source for Charlemagne's life and the Carolingian court.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Asser — The Life of King Alfred:** A Latin biography of King Alfred of Wessex, traditionally attributed to Asser, a Welsh monk who served at Alfred's court, probably written around 893. It covers Alfred's reign, including his wars against Viking invasions and his patronage of learning and translation. Its authenticity and precise date have been the subject of some scholarly debate.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle:** A set of related annalistic chronicles in Old English, originating during the reign of Alfred the Great in the late 9th century and continued at various monastic centers, with some versions extending into the 12th century. It records events in English history year by year. It is among the earliest sustained historical works composed in a European vernacular language.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Gildas — On the Ruin of Britain:** A Latin text by the British monk Gildas, probably written in the 6th century, combining historical narrative with a polemical condemnation of contemporary British rulers, whom Gildas blames for inviting Saxon settlement and conquest. It is one of the few surviving near-contemporary sources for sub-Roman Britain. Its historical reliability is debated among historians.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Jordanes — *Getica***: A Latin history of the Goths written by Jordanes in the mid-6th century, based substantially on the lost Gothic history of Cassiodorus. It presents an origin narrative for the Gothic peoples and traces their history into Jordanes's own time. It is a major surviving source for early Gothic history, though its reliability is debated.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Paul the Deacon — *History of the Lombards***: A Latin history of the Lombards, a Germanic people who established a kingdom in Italy, written by Paul the Deacon in the late 8th century at the Carolingian court. It covers Lombard history from their legendary origins to the mid-8th century, combining legendary and historical material. It is the principal narrative source for early Lombard history.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Geoffrey of Monmouth — *The History of the Kings of Britain***: A Latin pseudo-historical work completed around 1136, presenting a chronicle of British kings from a legendary Trojan founder to the 7th century, including an extensive account of King Arthur. Largely legendary or invented in content, it drew on earlier chronicle material as well as Geoffrey's own additions. It was highly influential in the development of the Arthurian legend and of subsequent medieval historical writing.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Procopius — *The Wars*; *The Secret History***: Works by Procopius of Caesarea, a Greek historian of the 6th century who served as secretary to the Byzantine general Belisarius. *The Wars* is an official account of Emperor Justinian's military campaigns; *The Secret History*, apparently intended for posthumous circulation, offers a critical account of Justinian, his wife Theodora, and Belisarius. The two works present markedly different portrayals of the same court and events.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **William of Malmesbury — *Deeds of the Kings of the English***: A Latin history of the kings of England from the 5th century to William's own time, written by the monk William of Malmesbury in the 1120s. It draws on and evaluates a range of earlier written sources with attention to source criticism. It is considered a significant work of English historical writing in the period following the Norman Conquest.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Jacobus de Voragine — *The Golden Legend***: A Latin compilation of hagiographies of saints, assembled by the Dominican friar Jacobus de Voragine around 1260. It was extensively copied, translated, and later printed, becoming one of the most widely circulated texts of the later Middle Ages. It influenced the iconography of saints in medieval art.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Saxo Grammaticus — *Gesta Danorum***: A Latin history of the Danes written by Saxo Grammaticus around 1200, covering legendary and historical Danish history from earliest times to the late 12th century. It includes the story of Amleth, later used as a source for Shakespeare's *Hamlet*. It combines Norse legendary material with chronicle history.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Adam of Bremen — *Deeds of the Bishops of Hamburg***: A Latin ecclesiastical history written around 1075–1076 by Adam, a canon of the church of Bremen, covering the history of the archbishopric of Hamburg-Bremen and its missionary activity in Scandinavia. It includes early descriptions of Scandinavian geography and pagan religious practice, including the temple at Uppsala, and one of the earliest European references to Vinland.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Anna Komnene — The Alexiad:** A Greek history written by Anna Komnene, daughter of the Byzantine emperor Alexios I Komnenos, in the mid-12th century, covering her father's reign from roughly 1069 to 1118. It includes an account of the arrival of the First Crusade in Byzantine territory. It is regarded as an early example of historical writing by a woman.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Otto of Freising — The Two Cities; Deeds of Frederick Barbarossa:** Works by Otto, bishop of Freising, a 12th-century historian and member of the Hohenstaufen dynasty. The Two Cities (*Historia de Duabus Civitatibus*) is a universal history structured around Augustine's concept of the earthly and heavenly cities. Deeds of Frederick Barbarossa is a biography of Otto's nephew, Emperor Frederick I, left unfinished at Otto's death and completed by his continuator Rahewin.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Geoffroi de Villehardouin — The Conquest of Constantinople:** An Old French prose account of the Fourth Crusade (1202-1204) by Geoffroi de Villehardouin, a knight and participant who served as a marshal and negotiator during the campaign. It recounts the diversion of the crusade to Constantinople and the city's capture and sack in 1204. It is considered one of the earliest examples of French historical prose.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Jean de Joinville — The Life of Saint Louis:** A French biography of King Louis IX of France, written by Jean de Joinville, a nobleman who accompanied Louis on the Seventh Crusade, completed around 1309. It combines an account of the crusade with personal anecdotes and reflections on Louis's character and piety. It is a primary source for the reign of Louis IX and for 13th-century French court life.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **John Scotus Eriugena — Periphyseon (On the Division of Nature):** A ninth-century Latin philosophical work structured as a dialogue, presenting a Neoplatonic account of the divisions of nature and the procession and return of all things to God. Eriugena translated the works of Pseudo-Dionysius into Latin, which influenced the treatise's system. Some of its propositions were later condemned by church authorities.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Peter Lombard — The Sentences:** A twelfth-century compilation organizing patristic and other theological opinions into four books covering God, creation, Christ, and the sacraments. It became the standard theology textbook in medieval universities, and commentary on it was a standard exercise for theologians, including Aquinas.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Hugh of St. Victor — Didascalicon:** A twelfth-century guide to the arts and sciences and to methods of reading and study, written by a canon of the Abbey of Saint-Victor in Paris. It organizes secular and sacred learning within a framework oriented toward biblical study and contemplation.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Richard of St. Victor — On the Trinity; The Mystical Ark:** Richard (d. 1173), a canon of Saint-Victor, wrote *On the Trinity*, which argues for the necessity of plurality in God from the nature of perfect love, and *The Mystical Ark*, which describes stages of contemplation.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **St. Albert the Great — On the Soul; the commentaries on Aristotle:** Albertus Magnus (c. 1200-1280) was a Dominican friar who wrote extensive commentaries on Aristotle's works, incorporating them into Christian scholarship, and also wrote on natural science. He was a teacher of Thomas Aquinas.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **John Duns Scotus — Ordinatio:** Scotus (c. 1266-1308) was a Franciscan philosopher and theologian known for his doctrines of univocity of being, formal distinction, and haecceity (individual "thisness"). The Ordinatio is his major work, a revision of his lecture commentary on Peter Lombard's Sentences.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **William of Ockham — Sum of Logic:** Ockham (c. 1287-1347) was an English Franciscan philosopher associated with nominalism, the position that universals do not exist independently of the mind. The Summa Logicae is a treatise on logic and philosophy of language; Ockham is also known for the methodological principle called Ockham's razor.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Ramon Llull — Ars Magna; Blanquerna:** Llull (c. 1232-1316) was a Catalan philosopher and missionary. The Ars Magna presents a combinatorial system intended to demonstrate religious truths logically; Blanquerna is a prose narrative about a man who becomes pope, written in Catalan.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Nicholas of Cusa — On Learned Ignorance:** Nicholas of Cusa (1401-1464) was a cardinal and philosopher. De Docta Ignorantia (1440) argues that human knowledge of the infinite God is necessarily limited and discusses the coincidence of opposites in the divine.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. John Climacus — The Ladder of Divine Ascent:** A seventh-century Greek text by John, abbot of Mount Sinai, describing thirty steps of ascetic and spiritual progress. It is used in Eastern Orthodox monastic practice, particularly during Lent.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Symeon the New Theologian — The Discourses; Hymns of Divine Love:** Symeon (949-1022) was a Byzantine monk and mystical writer who wrote of direct experiential knowledge of God, including visions of divine light, attainable during life. His writings influenced later Orthodox spirituality, including Palamism.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Gregory Palamas — The Triads (In Defense of the Holy Hesychasts):** A fourteenth-century Byzantine theologian, Palamas wrote in defense of hesychast monastic practice, including the Jesus Prayer. He formulated a distinction between God's essence, which is unknowable, and God's energies, through which humans experience divine grace.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Meister Eckhart — The Sermons:** Eckhart (c. 1260-1328) was a German Dominican theologian and mystic. His vernacular and Latin sermons discuss the soul's relationship to the Godhead using paradoxical and apophatic language; some propositions drawn from his teaching were condemned posthumously by Pope John XXII.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

- ☐ **Johannes Tauler — The Sermons:** Tauler (c. 1300-1361) was a German Dominican preacher associated with Rhineland mysticism and a student of Eckhart's teaching. His sermons address detachment and the inner spiritual life in more practical terms than Eckhart's.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Jan van Ruusbroec — The Spiritual Espousals:** Ruusbroec (1293-1381) was a Flemish mystic. This work describes three stages of the spiritual life — active, interior, and contemplative — culminating in union with God, using the image of spiritual marriage.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Hildegard of Bingen — Scivias:** Hildegard (1098-1179) was a Benedictine abbess, composer, and writer. Scivias records a series of visions concerning creation, salvation history, and the Church, accompanied by theological commentary.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Richard Rolle — The Fire of Love:** Rolle (c. 1300-1349) was an English hermit and mystical writer. The Fire of Love (Incendium Amoris) describes his religious experiences in terms of physical sensations of heat and sweetness and the perception of song.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Walter Hilton — The Scale of Perfection:** Hilton (d. 1396) was an English Augustinian canon. This work describes the soul's progress from active religious observance toward contemplative union with God, addressed to a reader pursuing the contemplative life.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **St. Catherine of Siena — The Dialogue:** Catherine (1347-1380) was an Italian Dominican tertiary involved in Church affairs, including efforts to return the papacy to Rome from Avignon. The Dialogue records a series of conversations between the soul and God, dictated by Catherine.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Boethius — The Theological Tractates (incl. De Trinitate):** Short Latin treatises by Boethius applying logical analysis to questions concerning the Trinity and the person of Christ. They were widely studied in medieval schools alongside the Consolation of Philosophy. (Companion to the Consolation, Book I.)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Henry Suso — The Little Book of Eternal Wisdom:** Suso (c. 1295-1366) was a German Dominican mystic and a student of Eckhart. This devotional work centers on meditation on the suffering of Christ and was widely circulated in the late medieval period.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Jean Gerson — On Mystical Theology:** Gerson (1363-1429) was chancellor of the University of Paris. His writings on mystical theology sought to distinguish contemplative experience from error and to address the subject within an academic and pastoral framework.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)
- ☐ **Joachim of Fiore — Exposition of the Apocalypse:** Joachim (c. 1135-1202) was a Calabrian abbot who proposed a theology of history divided into three ages, associated with the Father, the Son, and a coming age of the Spirit. His ideas influenced later apocalyptic and reform movements.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [CCEL](#)

Phase VI: Judaism and Islam

2nd to 20th c.. About 277 hours of core reading.

The rabbinic tradition and the Islamic world: scripture, law, commentary, philosophy, and Persian and Arabic poetry. The medieval Arabic philosophers transmitted and extended Aristotle, which is why they sit next to Phase 5's scholastics. Maimonides belongs to both traditions here.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. How does rabbinic argument (dispute preserved, not resolved) compare with scholastic method?
2. What are the central themes of the Qur'an, and how is it organized?
3. What is at stake between al-Ghazali and Averroes on philosophy and revelation?
4. What does Sufi poetry mean by love, and how does it compare with Phase 5's mystics?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Pirkei Avot (The Ethics of the Fathers)** (~2 h)

Read: The ethical sayings of the rabbis and the chain of transmission from Sinai.

Edition: Koren Pirkei Avot (Koren); free on Sefaria

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

2. ☐ **The Mishnah** (~15 h)

Read: Selected tractates: Berakhot, Shabbat, Sanhedrin.

Edition: Tr. Herbert Danby, The Mishnah (Oxford); or Jacob Neusner (Yale); free on Sefaria

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

3. ☐ **The Babylonian Talmud (Talmud Bavli)** (~20 h)

Read: Selections with a guide. Watch how a single Mishnah passage unfolds into layered debate.

Edition: Koren Talmud Bavli, Noe Edition (Koren); free on Sefaria (William Davidson edition). Guide: Barry Holtz, Back to the Sources (Simon & Schuster)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

4. ☐ **The Midrash — Midrash Rabbah; Pirkei de-Rabbi Eliezer; Tanhuma** (~8 h)

Read: Genesis Rabbah read alongside Genesis.

Edition: Midrash Rabbah, Soncino translation; selections in Bialik and Ravnitzky, The Book of Legends (Schocken); free on Sefaria

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

5. ☐ **Rashi — Commentary on the Torah and Talmud** (~10 h)

Read: Rashi on Genesis: the standard commentary printed beside the Torah text.

Edition: The Metsudah Linear Chumash with Rashi; free on Sefaria

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

6. ☐ **The Qur'an** (~30 h)

Read: A translation with notes. One common approach: the short Meccan suras at the end first, then from the beginning.

Edition: Tr. M.A.S. Abdel Haleem (Oxford World's Classics); The Study Quran, ed. Seyyed Hossein Nasr (HarperOne); free at [Quran.com](#)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

7. ☐ **Ibn Ishaq / Ibn Hisham — The Life of Muhammad (Sirat Rasul Allah)** (~20 h)
 Read: The earliest surviving biography of Muhammad, in Ibn Hisham's recension.
 Edition: Tr. A. Guillaume, *The Life of Muhammad* (Oxford)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

8. ☐ **Al-Nawawi — Forty Hadith** (~2 h)
 Read: A compact entry into the hadith literature. Hadith 2 (Gabriel) summarizes the faith.
 Edition: Tr. Ezzeddin Ibrahim and Denys Johnson-Davies (*Islamic Texts Society*)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

9. ☐ **The Mu'allaqat (The Seven Hanging Odes)** (~3 h)
 Read: Pre-Islamic odes: the deserted campsite, the journey, the boast.
 Edition: In A.J. Arberry, *The Seven Odes* (Allen & Unwin); or Michael Sells, *Desert Tracings* (Wesleyan)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

10. ☐ **Al-Farabi — The Virtuous City** (~6 h)
 Read: Plato's Republic reimagined with a philosopher-prophet as ruler.
 Edition: Tr. Richard Walzer, *Al-Farabi on the Perfect State* (Oxford / Kazi)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

11. ☐ **Avicenna (Ibn Sina) — The Book of Healing; The Canon of Medicine** (~12 h)
 Read: Selections: the metaphysics of necessary being and the 'floating man' argument from the Book of Healing.
 Edition: *The Metaphysics of The Healing*, tr. Michael Marmura (Brigham Young); selections in *Classical Arabic Philosophy*, tr. McGinnis and Reisman (Hackett)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

12. ☐ **Al-Ghazali — The Incoherence of the Philosophers; The Revival of the Religious Sciences; Deliverance from Error** (~12 h)
 Read: Deliverance from Error first (his autobiography), then the Incoherence of the Philosophers.
 Edition: *Deliverance from Error*, tr. R.J. McCarthy (Fons Vitae); *The Incoherence of the Philosophers*, tr. Michael Marmura (Brigham Young)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

13. ☐ **Averroes (Ibn Rushd) — The Incoherence of the Incoherence; The Decisive Treatise; the Aristotle commentaries** (~8 h)
 Read: The Decisive Treatise, then selections from the Incoherence of the Incoherence answering al-Ghazali.
 Edition: *The Decisive Treatise*, tr. Charles Butterworth (Brigham Young); *Tahafut al-Tahafut* tr. Simon van den Bergh (Gibb Memorial Trust)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

14. ☐ **Ibn Tufayl — Hayy ibn Yaqzan** (~4 h)
 Read: A child raised alone on an island reasons his way to God. Often compared with Robinson Crusoe.
 Edition: Tr. Lenn Evan Goodman, *Hayy Ibn Yaqzan* (Chicago)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

15. ☐ **Moses Maimonides — The Guide for the Perplexed** (~20 h)
 Read: The introduction, Part I on divine attributes, and Part III on providence and the reasons for the commandments.
 Edition: Tr. Shlomo Pines, *The Guide of the Perplexed* (Chicago, 2 vols.); abridged ed. Julius Guttman (Hackett)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

16. ☐ **Judah Halevi — The Kuzari** (~8 h)

Read: A king questions a philosopher, a Christian, a Muslim, and a rabbi. A counterpoint to Maimonides.

Edition: Tr. Hartwig Hirschfeld, *The Kuzari* (Schocken); free on Sefaria

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

17. ☐ **Ferdowsi — The Shahnameh (The Book of Kings)** (~25 h)

Read: An abridged translation. The story of Rostam and Sohrab is the best-known episode.

Edition: Tr. Dick Davis, *Shahnameh: The Persian Book of Kings* (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

18. ☐ **Attar — The Conference of the Birds** (~6 h)

Read: The birds' journey through seven valleys to the Simorgh.

Edition: Tr. Afkham Darbandi and Dick Davis (Penguin); or Sholeh Wolpe (Norton)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

19. ☐ **Rumi — The Masnavi; Diwan-e Shams-e Tabrizi; Fihi Ma Fihi** (~12 h)

Read: Masnavi Book I, beginning with the song of the reed.

Edition: *The Masnavi, Book One*, tr. Jawid Mojaddedi (Oxford World's Classics); ghazals tr. A.J. Arberry, *Mystical Poems of Rumi* (Chicago)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

20. ☐ **Saadi — The Gulistan; The Bustan** (~5 h)

Read: The Gulistan: prose and verse anecdotes of conduct.

Edition: *The Gulistan* tr. Wheeler Thackston (Ibex)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

21. ☐ **Hafiz — The Divan** (~5 h)

Read: A selection of ghazals. Goethe's West-Eastern Divan (not on this list) was written in response to him.

Edition: Tr. Dick Davis, *Faces of Love: Hafez and the Poets of Shiraz* (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

22. ☐ **Anon. — The Thousand and One Nights** (~20 h)

Read: The frame tale of Shahrazad and a selection; note the nested stories.

Edition: Tr. Husain Haddawy, *The Arabian Nights* (Norton); or Malcolm and Ursula Lyons (Penguin, 3 vols.)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

23. ☐ **Ibn Khaldun — The Muqaddimah** (~20 h)

Read: The theory of asabiyya (group solidarity) and the rise and fall of dynasties.

Edition: Tr. Franz Rosenthal, abridged by N.J. Dawood, *The Muqaddimah* (Princeton)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

24. ☐ **Martin Buber — I and Thou** (~4 h)

Read: A modern bridge: the I-Thou and I-It relations.

Edition: Tr. Walter Kaufmann, *I and Thou* (Scribner / Touchstone)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

Synthesis. Set Maimonides, Averroes, and Aquinas side by side on the relation of reason and revelation.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **The Tosefta:** A companion collection of tannaitic teachings organized parallel to the Mishnah's structure, containing material not included in the Mishnah, including additional rulings and discussions.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **The Jerusalem Talmud (Talmud Yerushalmi):** Compiled in the Land of Israel and completed earlier than the Babylonian Talmud, around the 4th-5th century AD. It comments on the Mishnah and preserves traditions and rulings distinct from those in the Babylonian Talmud.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **The Targums — Onkelos; Jonathan:** Aramaic translations of the Hebrew Bible, produced for congregational and study use after Aramaic replaced Hebrew as the everyday language of many Jewish communities. They combine translation with interpretive additions.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Moses Maimonides — The Mishneh Torah; the Thirteen Principles of Faith:** Maimonides (1138-1204) was a rabbi, philosopher, and physician. The Mishneh Torah is a comprehensive code organizing Jewish law by topic; the Thirteen Principles summarize core tenets of Jewish belief, formulated in his commentary on the Mishnah.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Joseph Karo — The Shulchan Aruch:** A sixteenth-century code of Jewish law compiled by Joseph Karo, organized by topic and covering daily religious practice, festivals, and personal and civil law. It became a standard legal reference, supplemented by later glosses reflecting Ashkenazi custom.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Saadia Gaon — The Book of Beliefs and Opinions:** Saadia Gaon (882-942), head of the Sura academy in Babylonia, wrote this work of Jewish philosophy in Arabic, addressing the relationship between reason and revelation and defending Jewish doctrine using philosophical argument.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Bahya ibn Paquda — Duties of the Heart:** An eleventh-century work of Jewish ethics, written in Arabic, distinguishing between the "duties of the limbs" (external observance) and the "duties of the heart" (internal states such as humility, trust, and sincerity).
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Sefer ha-Bahir (The Book of Brightness):** An early Kabbalistic text, appearing in the twelfth century, presenting concepts including the sefirot (divine emanations) and the transmigration of souls in a cryptic, symbolic style.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Abraham Abulafia — The Light of the Intellect:** Abulafia (1240-c. 1291) developed a form of Kabbalah involving meditative techniques based on combinations of Hebrew letters and divine names, aimed at inducing prophetic or ecstatic states.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Joseph Gikatilla — Gates of Light:** A thirteenth-century Kabbalistic text by Joseph Gikatilla explaining the ten sefirot and their associated divine names, intended as an introductory guide to Kabbalistic symbolism.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)

- ☐ **Moses Cordovero — Pardes Rimoni**: A sixteenth-century systematic treatise by the Safed Kabbalist Moses Cordovero, organizing earlier Kabbalistic teachings, particularly concerning the sefirot, into a structured theological framework.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Isaac Luria & Chaim Vital — Etz Chaim (The Tree of Life)**: Records the teachings of Isaac Luria (1534-1572), a Kabbalist active in Safed, as compiled by his student Chaim Vital. Central concepts include tzimtzum (divine self-contraction), the breaking of the vessels, and tikkun (repair), describing the process of creation and its restoration.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Moses Chaim Luzzatto — The Path of the Just (Mesillat Yesharim)**: An eighteenth-century Italian work of Jewish ethics describing stages of moral and spiritual development, from care in observance to piety and holiness, drawing on earlier rabbinic sources including Pirkei Avot.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Sefer Raziel HaMalakh**: A compilation of Kabbalistic, angelological, and magical material, traditionally attributed to the angel Raziel, including material on amulets and cosmology, circulated from the medieval period onward.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **The Passover Haggadah**: The text recited during the Passover seder, recounting the biblical account of the Exodus from Egypt and structuring the ritual meal, including prescribed blessings, questions, and readings.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Nachman of Breslov — Likutei Moharan; The Tales**: Nachman of Breslov (1772-1810) was a Hasidic rabbi. Likutei Moharan collects his teachings and discourses; his tales are a series of allegorical stories addressing themes of faith and struggle, recorded by his followers.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Abraham Joshua Heschel — The Sabbath; God in Search of Man**: Heschel (1907-1972) was a rabbi and theologian. The Sabbath discusses the Jewish observance of the Sabbath as a structuring of time; God in Search of Man presents his approach to Jewish theology and the concept of divine pathos.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Sefaria](#)
- ☐ **Antarah ibn Shaddad — Diwan; Sirat Antar**: Antarah was a pre-Islamic poet-warrior, son of an Arab father and an enslaved Ethiopian mother, known for verses on love and battle addressed to his beloved Abla. The Sirat Antar is a later popular romance elaborating his life into an extended chivalric narrative.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Abu Nuwas — Diwan**: An Abbasid-era poet (c. 756-814) known for verse on wine and love, as well as satire and hunting poems, associated with the court culture of Baghdad. His work departed from the conventions of earlier Arabic poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Al-Mutanabbi — Diwan**: A tenth-century Arabic poet (915-965) known for panegyric and self-praise poetry composed for various rulers and patrons. His verse is frequently cited in later Arabic literary and rhetorical tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Abu al-Ala al-Maarri — The Epistle of Forgiveness; Luzumiyyat:** Al-Maarri (973-1057) was a blind Syrian poet and writer. The Epistle of Forgiveness depicts a journey through the afterlife and has been compared to Dante's Divine Comedy; the Luzumiyyat is a poetry collection expressing skeptical and ascetic views, including criticism of organized religion.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Ibn al-Muqaffa — Kalila wa Dimna:** An eighth-century Arabic adaptation, by Ibn al-Muqaffa, of Indian animal fables originating in the Sanskrit Panchatantra, concerning statecraft and ethics, told through the interactions of animal characters. It was translated into numerous languages in subsequent centuries.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Al-Hariri — The Maqamat:** A collection of fifty narrative episodes composed by al-Hariri of Basra (1054-1122) in rhymed prose (saj') featuring a recurring eloquent and roguish protagonist. The maqamat form emphasizes linguistic virtuosity and wordplay.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Usama ibn Munqidh — The Book of Contemplation:** A memoir by a twelfth-century Syrian nobleman and warrior describing his experiences during the Crusades, including encounters with Frankish crusaders, alongside accounts of hunting and court life.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Sahih al-Bukhari (a selection):** A ninth-century collection of hadith (reports of the sayings and actions of Muhammad) compiled by Muhammad al-Bukhari, organized by subject and evaluated for the reliability of their chains of transmission (isnad). It is regarded by Sunni Muslims as one of the most authoritative hadith collections.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Sahih Muslim:** A hadith collection compiled by Muslim ibn al-Hajjaj in the ninth century, regarded alongside Sahih al-Bukhari as one of the two collections given the highest degree of authority in Sunni Islam.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Al-Tabari — History of the Prophets and Kings:** A universal history by the ninth/tenth-century scholar al-Tabari, covering events from creation through the author's own time, including pre-Islamic history and the early Islamic period, compiled from earlier sources and oral traditions.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Rudaki — Diwan:** Rudaki (c. 858-941) is regarded as one of the earliest major poets writing in New Persian, active at the Samanid court in Bukhara. Only fragments of his extensive body of work survive.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Sanai — The Walled Garden of Truth:** A twelfth-century Persian poem by Sanai of Ghazna, generally considered among the earliest major works to use the Persian masnawi (rhyming couplet) form for extended Sufi religious instruction, combining doctrine, parable, and homily.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Nizami Ganjavi — The Khamsa (Layla and Majnun; Khosrow and Shirin; The Seven Beauties):** A collection of five narrative poems composed in the twelfth century by Nizami, including Layla and Majnun (the story of ill-fated lovers), Khosrow and Shirin, and The Seven Beauties (Haft Paykar). The poems combine romance with historical and legendary material.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

- ☐ **Jami — Yusuf and Zulaikha; Haft Awrang:** Jami (1414-1492) was a Persian poet and Sufi scholar, often regarded as among the last of the major classical Persian poets. Yusuf and Zulaikha retells the biblical/Quranic story of Joseph as a Sufi allegory of love; Haft Awrang ("Seven Thrones") is a collection of seven narrative poems.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Al-Kindi — On First Philosophy:** Al-Kindi (c. 801-873), known as "the philosopher of the Arabs," was among the first to systematically incorporate Greek philosophical concepts into Arabic-language Islamic thought. On First Philosophy addresses metaphysics and argues for the compatibility of philosophy with Islamic doctrine.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Suhrawardi — The Philosophy of Illumination:** Shihab al-Din Suhrawardi (1154-1191) founded the Illuminationist (Ishraqi) school of Islamic philosophy, presenting a metaphysics organized around degrees of light emanating from a "Light of Lights," drawing on Platonic and Zoroastrian sources. He was executed in Aleppo.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Ibn Arabi — The Bezels of Wisdom; The Meccan Revelations:** Ibn Arabi (1165-1240) was an Andalusian Sufi philosopher known for the doctrine of wahdat al-wujud (the unity of being). The Bezels of Wisdom (Fusus al-Hikam) discusses the spiritual character of successive prophets; The Meccan Revelations (al-Futuh al-Makkiyya) is an extensive compendium of his mystical and philosophical teachings.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Omar Khayyam — Treatise on Algebra:** Omar Khayyam (1048-1131), better known in the West for his quatrains (the Rubaiyat), was also a mathematician and astronomer. His algebraic treatise classifies and provides geometric solutions to cubic equations; he also contributed to the reform of the Persian solar calendar.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Al-Jahiz — The Book of Animals; The Book of Misers:** Al-Jahiz (c. 776-868) was an Abbasid-era prose writer. The Book of Animals is a wide-ranging compilation combining zoological material with anecdote and digression; The Book of Misers collects satirical anecdotes about miserly behavior.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Al-Masudi — The Meadows of Gold:** Al-Masudi (c. 896-956) was a historian and geographer. The Meadows of Gold is a wide-ranging work combining history, geography, and anecdote drawn from his travels and reading, covering regions from the Islamic world to India and beyond.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Rabia al-Adawiyya — Poems and Sayings:** Rabia al-Adawiyya (c. 717-801) was an early female Sufi figure from Basra, associated with the teaching that God should be loved for God's own sake, without hope of reward or fear of punishment. Her sayings survive primarily through later biographical and hagiographical sources.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Al-Hallaj — The Tawasin; the poems:** Al-Hallaj (858-922) was a Sufi mystic executed in Baghdad, reportedly in part for the statement "ana al-Haqq" ("I am the Truth"), interpreted as a claim of mystical union with God. The Tawasin is a collection of his prose and poetic writings.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)
- ☐ **Nasir Khusraw — Diwan; Safarnama:** Nasir Khusraw (1004-1088) was a Persian poet, philosopher, and Ismaili missionary. The Safarnama recounts a seven-year journey he made to Mecca, Cairo, and other regions; his Diwan addresses ethical and religious themes.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Quran.com](#)

Phase VII: India, China, and Japan

c. 1500 BC to 18th c.. About 257 hours of core reading.

Three linked traditions. India first (Veda, Upanishads, epics, early Buddhism), then China (Confucian and Daoist classics, poetry), then Buddhism's development through Madhyamaka and Chan into Japanese Zen and the warrior literature. The later sections of this phase assume the earlier ones.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What do the Upanishads mean by atman and brahman, and how does the Buddha's teaching of anatta respond?
2. What does Krishna tell Arjuna about action and its fruits?
3. Where do Confucius and Laozi agree, and where do they part?
4. How does Zen's emphasis on direct experience relate to the sutras it inherited?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **The Rigveda (the Vedic hymns)** (~8 h)

Read: Selected hymns, including the Creation Hymn (X.129) and the Purusha hymn (X.90).

Edition: Tr. Wendy Doniger, *The Rig Veda: An Anthology* (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

2. ☐ **The Principal Upanishads — Isha, Katha, Kena, Mundaka, Chandogya, Brihadaranyaka** (~10 h)

Read: Isha and Katha first (short), then Chandogya VI (tat tvam asi) and Brihadaranyaka.

Edition: Tr. Patrick Olivelle, *Upanisads* (Oxford World's Classics); or Eknath Easwaran (Nilgiri)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

3. ☐ **The Bhagavad Gita** (~5 h)

Read: Read twice: once for the story, once for the three yogas of action, knowledge, and devotion.

Edition: Tr. Laurie Patton (Penguin) or Eknath Easwaran (Nilgiri)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

4. ☐ **Valmiki — The Ramayana** (~20 h)

Read: An abridged translation is standard for a first reading.

Edition: Abridged tr. Arshia Sattar (Penguin); or R.K. Narayan's prose retelling (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

5. ☐ **Vyasa (attrib.) — The Mahabharata** (~40 h)

Read: An abridgment. The Gita sits inside it; now read it in context.

Edition: Abridged tr. John D. Smith (Penguin); or C. Rajagopalachari's retelling (Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

6. ☐ **The Pali Canon (Tipitaka) — the Digha and Majjhima Nikayas** (~20 h)

Read: Digha Nikaya 2 and 16 (the Buddha's last days); Majjhima Nikaya 22 (the raft) and 63 (the poisoned arrow).

Edition: Tr. Bhikkhu Nanamoli and Bhikkhu Bodhi, *The Middle Length Discourses* (Wisdom); Maurice Walshe, *The Long Discourses* (Wisdom); Bhikkhu Bodhi, *In the Buddha's Words* (Wisdom) as an anthology; free at SuttaCentral

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

7. ☐ **The Dhammapada** (~3 h)
- Read: Short verses on the Theravada path.
Edition: Tr. Gil Fronsdal (Shambhala) or Valerie Roebuck (Penguin)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
8. ☐ **Patanjali — The Yoga Sutras** (~4 h)
- Read: The eight limbs, with a commentary.
Edition: Tr. Edwin F. Bryant, The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali (North Point)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
9. ☐ **Nagarjuna — The Fundamental Verses on the Middle Way** (~6 h)
- Read: Chapters 1, 18, 24, 25 with a commentary. Emptiness and the two truths.
Edition: Tr. Jay L. Garfield, The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way (Oxford)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
10. ☐ **The Heart Sutra** (~1 h)
- Read: One page: 'form is emptiness, emptiness is form.'
Edition: Red Pine, The Heart Sutra (Counterpoint); or in Edward Conze, Buddhist Wisdom Books (Allen & Unwin)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
11. ☐ **The Diamond Sutra** (~2 h)
- Read: Short. The oldest dated printed book (868) is a copy of it.
Edition: Red Pine, The Diamond Sutra (Counterpoint)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
12. ☐ **Shantideva — The Way of the Bodhisattva** (~8 h)
- Read: Chapter 6 (patience) and chapter 8 (exchanging self and other).
Edition: Tr. Padmakara Translation Group, The Way of the Bodhisattva (Shambhala); or Crosby and Skilton, The Bodhicaryavatara (Oxford World's Classics)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
13. ☐ **Confucius — The Analects** (~5 h)
- Read: Ren (humaneness), li (ritual), the junzi (gentleman).
Edition: Tr. Edward Slingerland (Hackett) or D.C. Lau (Penguin); free at Chinese Text Project (Legge)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
14. ☐ **Mencius — The Mencius** (~6 h)
- Read: The four sprouts (2A6) and the claim that human nature is good.
Edition: Tr. Bryan Van Norden (Hackett) or D.C. Lau (Penguin); free at Chinese Text Project (Legge)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
15. ☐ **Laozi — Tao Te Ching** (~3 h)
- Read: Compare two translations; they diverge widely.
Edition: Tr. D.C. Lau (Penguin) and Stephen Addiss and Stanley Lombardo (Hackett); compare two
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
16. ☐ **Zhuangzi — The Zhuangzi** (~8 h)
- Read: The Inner Chapters (1-7): the butterfly dream, Cook Ding.
Edition: Tr. Burton Watson, The Complete Works of Zhuangzi (Columbia); or Brook Ziporyn (Hackett)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

17. ☐ **Sun Tzu — The Art of War** (~3 h)
Read: Short. Winning without fighting; knowing yourself and the enemy.
Edition: Tr. Samuel B. Griffith (Oxford) or Victor Mair (Columbia)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
18. ☐ **The I Ching (Book of Changes)** (~5 h)
Read: The structure of the 64 hexagrams and the Great Commentary (Xici).
Edition: Tr. Richard Wilhelm, rendered by Cary F. Baynes (Princeton, Bollingen)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
19. ☐ **The Shijing (The Book of Songs)** (~4 h)
Read: A selection; Confucius is said to have compiled it.
Edition: Tr. Arthur Waley, The Book of Songs (Grove)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
20. ☐ **Du Fu (Tu Fu) — Poems** (~3 h)
Read: With Li Bai, the two poets of the high Tang. Du Fu writes war and displacement.
Edition: Tr. David Hinton, The Selected Poems of Tu Fu (New Directions); or Stephen Owen, The Poetry of Du Fu (De Gruyter, open access)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
21. ☐ **Huineng — The Platform Sutra of the Sixth Patriarch** (~3 h)
Read: The poetry contest for the patriarchate and the teaching of sudden awakening.
Edition: Tr. Philip Yampolsky, The Platform Sutra of the Sixth Patriarch (Columbia); or Red Pine (Counterpoint)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
22. ☐ **Anon. — The Gateless Gate (Mumonkan)** (~4 h)
Read: Forty-eight koans. Case 1 (Zhaozhou's Mu) is the classic first koan.
Edition: Tr. Koun Yamada, The Gateless Gate (Wisdom)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
23. ☐ **Dogen — Shobogenzo; Fukanzazengi** (~8 h)
Read: Fukanzazengi, then the Genjokoan and Uji (Being-Time) fascicles of the Shobogenzo.
Edition: Ed. Kazuaki Tanahashi, Moon in a Dewdrop (North Point), which includes Fukanzazengi, Genjokoan and Uji
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
24. ☐ **Murasaki Shikibu — The Tale of Genji** (~40 h)
Read: The first third at least; an abridgment is acceptable for a first reading.
Edition: Tr. Royall Tyler (Penguin) or Dennis Washburn (Norton); abridged Tyler edition (Penguin)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
25. ☐ **Anon. — The Tale of the Heike** (~20 h)
Read: Opens on impermanence (the bell of Gion). The Genpei War.
Edition: Tr. Royall Tyler (Penguin) or Helen Craig McCullough (Stanford)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
26. ☐ **Kenko — Essays in Idleness (Tsurezuregusa)** (~4 h)
Read: Short essays on impermanence and taste.
Edition: Tr. Donald Keene, Essays in Idleness (Columbia)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

27. ☐ **Matsuo Basho — The Narrow Road to the Deep North** (~3 h)

Read: Travel prose with haiku. Read slowly.

Edition: Tr. Sam Hamill (Shambhala) or Nobuyuki Yuasa (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

28. ☐ **Takuan Soho — The Unfettered Mind** (~2 h)

Read: Letters to a swordsman on the mind that does not stop.

Edition: Tr. William Scott Wilson, The Unfettered Mind (Shambhala)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

29. ☐ **Miyamoto Musashi — The Book of Five Rings** (~3 h)

Read: The Water and Void books.

Edition: Tr. William Scott Wilson (Shambhala) or Thomas Cleary (Shambhala)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

30. ☐ **Yamamoto Tsunetomo — Hagakure** (~6 h)

Read: A selection; it was compiled from conversations c. 1716.

Edition: Tr. William Scott Wilson, Hagakure (Shambhala)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

Synthesis. Compare the Bhagavad Gita's teaching on action with the Stoics (Phase 3) and with the Hagakure.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Inazo Nitobe — Bushido: The Soul of Japan:** A book written in English and published in 1900 by the Japanese educator and diplomat Inazo Nitobe, intended to explain samurai ethical principles to a Western readership. It presents bushido as a code comparable to European chivalry, covering virtues such as loyalty, honor, and self-control. It was influential in shaping early 20th-century Western perceptions of Japanese culture.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **The Kojiki:** The oldest extant chronicle of Japan, compiled in 712 AD, recording mythological accounts of the creation of Japan and its gods alongside a genealogy of the early imperial line. It is a primary source for Shinto mythology and early Japanese history.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Omar Khayyam — The Rubaiyat:** A collection of quatrains (rubaiyat) attributed to the Persian polymath Omar Khayyam (1048-1131), addressing themes of mortality, fate, and the pleasures of the present moment. The attribution and authenticity of many individual verses are disputed among scholars. It became widely known in English through Edward FitzGerald's 1859 translation, which adapted rather than literally rendered the original Persian.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **The Four Books — The Great Learning; The Doctrine of the Mean:** Two short texts, originally chapters of the Book of Rites, later compiled with the Analects and the Mencius into the "Four Books" of Confucianism by the Song-dynasty scholar Zhu Xi. They address self-cultivation, moral development, and the relationship between the individual and the well-ordered state. The Four Books formed the basis of the Chinese imperial civil service examination curriculum for several centuries.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)

- ☐ **Sei Shonagon — The Pillow Book:** A collection of observations, lists, and anecdotes written around 1000 AD by Sei Shonagon, a lady-in-waiting at the Japanese imperial court during the Heian period. It combines diary-like entries with categorized lists of impressions and preferences. It is considered an early example of the *zuihitsu* ("following the brush") genre of Japanese literature.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Kakuzo Okakura — The Book of Tea:** A short book written in English and published in 1906 by the Japanese scholar Kakuzo Okakura, explaining the aesthetic and philosophical principles behind the Japanese tea ceremony to Western readers. It discusses the influence of Zen Buddhism and Taoism on Japanese approaches to art and daily life. It was written partly in response to Western misunderstandings of Japanese culture at the time.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Qu Yuan — The Songs of Chu (Li Sao):** A collection of poems associated with the statesman and poet Qu Yuan (c. 340-278 BC) of the state of Chu, along with later additions by other poets. Qu Yuan is traditionally said to have drowned himself after being exiled on charges of disloyalty. The Dragon Boat Festival is traditionally linked to his death.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Tao Yuanming — Collected Poems:** The poetry of Tao Yuanming (also known as Tao Qian, 365-427 AD), a Chinese official who retired from government service to live as a farmer. His verse depicts rural life, wine, and contentment with a simple existence, often centered on imagery of chrysanthemums and the countryside. He is regarded as an early and influential figure in Chinese nature poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Li Bai (Li Po) — Poems:** The poetry of Li Bai (701-762 AD), a Tang-dynasty poet known for verse on themes of nature, friendship, and wine. His work is associated with the high point of Tang-dynasty poetry and is often discussed alongside that of his contemporary Du Fu. Roughly a thousand of his poems survive.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Wang Wei — Poems:** The poetry of Wang Wei (699-759 AD), a Tang-dynasty poet, painter, and government official known for landscape poetry influenced by Buddhist contemplation. His verse frequently depicts natural scenes with an emphasis on stillness and quiet observation. He was also a noted landscape painter, and later critics linked the two aspects of his work.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [Chinese Text Project](#)
- ☐ **Adi Shankara — Crest-Jewel of Discrimination; the Upanishad commentaries:** Adi Shankara (traditionally dated to the 8th century AD) was a philosopher associated with the Advaita (non-dualist) school of Vedanta, holding that Brahman alone is ultimately real and that the perceived world of multiplicity is due to ignorance (*avidya*). He wrote commentaries on the Upanishads, the Brahma Sutras, and the Bhagavad Gita.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Laws of Manu (Manusmriti):** A Sanskrit legal and religious text, compiled roughly between the 2nd century BC and 2nd century AD, addressing social duty (*dharma*) organized by caste (*varna*) and stage of life (*ashrama*), along with cosmology and ritual matters. It has been an influential, and in the modern period a debated, text in the history of Hindu law.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Kautilya — The Arthashastra:** A Sanskrit treatise on statecraft, economics, and military strategy, traditionally attributed to Kautilya (also known as Chanakya), a minister associated with the Maurya court around the 4th century BC, though its final compilation may be later. It addresses administration, taxation, diplomacy, and espionage.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Kalidasa — Shakuntala; The Cloud Messenger; The Birth of Kumara:** Kalidasa (active c. 4th-5th century AD) was a Sanskrit poet and dramatist. *Shakuntala* (*Abhijnanashakuntalam*) is a play recounting the love story of King Dushyanta and Shakuntala; *The Cloud Messenger* (*Meghaduta*) is a lyric poem in which an exiled figure sends a message via a cloud; *The Birth of Kumara* (*Kumarasambhava*) narrates the birth of the god Kartikeya.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **The Panchatantra:** A Sanskrit collection of interlinked animal fables, compiled in its earliest known form around the 3rd century AD, intended to instruct princes in practical wisdom and statecraft. It was widely translated and adapted, including as the Arabic *Kalila wa Dimna*.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Bhartrhari — The Three Centuries (Shataktraya):** A collection of Sanskrit epigrams attributed to Bhartrhari (dates uncertain, possibly 5th century AD), traditionally divided into three sets of roughly one hundred verses each, on worldly conduct, love, and renunciation.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Jayadeva — The Gitagovinda:** A twelfth-century Sanskrit lyric poem by Jayadeva describing the love of the god Krishna and the cowherd Radha. It has been read both as erotic poetry and as religious allegory and has influenced later devotional literature, music, and dance traditions.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Rabindranath Tagore — Gitanjali; The Home and the World; selected poems:** Tagore (1861-1941) was a Bengali poet, writer, and composer. *Gitanjali* ("Song Offerings") is a collection of devotional poems for which he received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913, the first non-European recipient of the prize; *The Home and the World* is a novel addressing nationalism and personal relationships set during the Swadeshi movement.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Tiruvalluvar — Tirukkural:** A Tamil text of couplets, of uncertain date (estimates range from roughly the 1st century BC to the 5th century AD), traditionally attributed to Tiruvalluvar, addressing virtue (*aram*), wealth and governance (*porul*), and love (*inbam*).
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Sudraka — The Little Clay Cart (Mrcchakatika):** A Sanskrit drama traditionally attributed to a king or author named Sudraka, of uncertain date (estimates range from around the 2nd century BC to the 5th century AD), depicting the relationship between an impoverished merchant, Charudatta, and a courtesan, Vasantasena, against a backdrop of political intrigue.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Tulsidas — Ramcharitmanas:** A sixteenth-century retelling of the Ramayana in Awadhi (a dialect of Hindi) by the poet Tulsidas, presenting the story of Rama within a devotional (*bhakti*) framework. It is widely read and performed in northern India, including in the annual Ramlila dramatic tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Kabir — Poems (the Bijak; the dohas):** Kabir (traditionally dated to around the 15th century) was a North Indian poet-saint associated with the bhakti and Sant traditions, whose verses, preserved in collections such as the Bijak, criticize ritual formalism in both Hindu and Muslim practice and emphasize direct devotion to a formless God (nirguna).
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Yagyu Munenori — The Life-Giving Sword (Heiho Kadensho):** A treatise on swordsmanship written in 1632 by Yagyu Munenori, sword instructor to the Tokugawa shoguns. It discusses technique alongside Zen-influenced concepts of perception, timing, and the mental state of the swordsman. It is a foundational text of the Yagyu Shinkage-ryu school of swordsmanship.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **Bodhidharma — The Two Entrances and Four Practices; The Bloodstream Sermon:** Texts attributed to Bodhidharma, a monk traditionally credited with transmitting Chan (Zen) Buddhism from India to China in the 5th or 6th century. They describe entering the Buddhist path through principle and through practice, emphasizing direct insight into one's nature over reliance on scripture. Bodhidharma is traditionally regarded as the first patriarch of Chan Buddhism and is associated with the Shaolin Monastery.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **Yuanwu — The Blue Cliff Record (Hekiganroku):** A collection of one hundred koans with commentary, compiled in 12th-century China by the Chan master Yuanwu Keqin, based on earlier selections by Xuedou Zhongxian. It combines case narratives, verse commentary, and prose commentary. It is used as a teaching text in the Rinzai Zen tradition.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **Hakuin — Wild Ivy; the koan teachings:** Writings including the spiritual autobiography of Hakuin Ekaku, an 18th-century Japanese monk who revived the Rinzai school of Zen. He developed new koans, including the well-known "what is the sound of one hand clapping," and reorganized koan training. Wild Ivy recounts his meditative experiences and periods of illness and doubt.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **Eugen Herrigel — Zen in the Art of Archery:** A 1948 memoir by the German philosopher Eugen Herrigel describing his study of Japanese archery (kyūdō) under a Zen-influenced teacher in the 1920s. It describes the practice of shooting without deliberate aiming or self-conscious effort. It became a widely read introduction to Zen concepts for Western readers.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **D.T. Suzuki — Zen and Japanese Culture:** A study by the scholar D.T. Suzuki examining the influence of Zen Buddhism on Japanese art forms, including swordsmanship, tea ceremony, haiku, and garden design. First published in expanded form in 1959. Suzuki's writings introduced Zen concepts to a wide English-speaking readership in the 20th century.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)
- ☐ **Shunryu Suzuki — Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind:** A 1970 collection of talks by Shunryū Suzuki, a Sōtō Zen priest who founded the San Francisco Zen Center. It presents basic Zen practice and attitudes toward meditation for a general audience, including the phrase "beginner's mind." It is widely used as an introductory text on Zen practice in the West.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Lotus Sutra:** A Mahayana Buddhist sutra composed roughly between the 1st century BCE and 2nd century CE, teaching that all beings are capable of attaining buddhahood. It uses parables, including that of a father luring children from a burning house, to illustrate the Buddha's use of skillful means (upaya). It has been particularly influential in East Asian Buddhist traditions, including Tiantai and Nichiren Buddhism.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Vimalakirti Sutra:** A Mahayana sutra in which the layman Vimalakīrti debates Buddhist doctrine with bodhisattvas and disciples of the Buddha. A key passage has Vimalakīrti respond to a question about non-duality with silence. The text emphasizes that lay practitioners can attain deep spiritual realization.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Lankavatara Sutra:** A Mahayana sutra addressing the doctrine that phenomena are manifestations of mind (cittamatra, or "mind-only"). It was influential in early Chinese Chan Buddhism and is associated with the transmission of Zen from Bodhidharma. It discusses perception, consciousness, and the nature of reality.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Sutta Nipata; The Udana:** Two texts included in the Khuddaka Nikaya of the Pali Canon, considered among its oldest strata. The Sutta Nipāta is a collection of verse discourses, and the Udāna is a collection of the Buddha's inspired utterances paired with narrative context. Both are associated with early Theravada Buddhist teaching.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **Buddhaghosa — The Visuddhimagga (The Path of Purification):** A comprehensive manual of Theravada Buddhist doctrine and meditation practice, composed in Pali by the 5th-century scholar-monk Buddhaghosa in Sri Lanka. It organizes the path to liberation into stages of ethical conduct, concentration, and wisdom. It remains an authoritative reference text in the Theravada tradition.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Milindapanha (The Questions of King Milinda):** A text presenting a dialogue between the Indo-Greek king Menander I (Milinda) and the Buddhist monk Nagasena, likely composed in the early centuries CE. It addresses questions of Buddhist doctrine, including the nature of the self and rebirth, using the analogy of a chariot to illustrate the concept of no-self (anatta). It is regarded as a significant text in Theravada Buddhist literature.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Jataka Tales:** A collection of several hundred stories describing the previous lives of the Buddha, included in the Pali Canon's Khuddaka Nikaya. Each tale illustrates a moral or virtue associated with the bodhisattva path. The stories have also circulated widely as folk literature across South and Southeast Asia.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Tibetan Book of the Dead (Bardo Thodol):** A Tibetan Buddhist text traditionally attributed to Padmasambhava and said to be discovered in the 14th century by Karma Lingpa, used as a guide for the dying and recently deceased. It describes the intermediate state (bardo) between death and rebirth and practices for recognizing the nature of mind during this period. It was first translated into English in 1927 by Walter Evans-Wentz.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Life of Milarepa; The Hundred Thousand Songs:** Texts recounting the life and teachings of Milarepa, an 11th-12th century Tibetan yogi of the Kagyu lineage. The biography describes his early practice of sorcery, subsequent remorse, and ascetic training under his teacher Marpa; the songs record his spontaneous verse teachings. He is a widely known figure in Tibetan Buddhist literature.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **Gampopa — The Jewel Ornament of Liberation:** A systematic exposition of the Buddhist path composed by Gampopa, a 12th-century disciple of Milarepa who integrated monastic and yogic traditions. It presents stages of practice from initial motivation through to buddhahood. It is a foundational text of the Kagyu school of Tibetan Buddhism.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **Patrul Rinpoche — The Words of My Perfect Teacher:** A 19th-century manual of the preliminary practices (ngöndro) of the Nyingma school of Tibetan Buddhism, written by Patrul Rinpoche. It combines doctrinal instruction with stories and anecdotes. It remains widely used as an introductory text in Nyingma and Dzogchen practice.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **Tsongkhapa — The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path (Lamrim Chenmo):** A systematic presentation of the Buddhist path to enlightenment composed in 1402 by Tsongkhapa, founder of the Gelug school of Tibetan Buddhism. It organizes teachings into a graduated sequence of stages (lamrim) drawing on Indian Buddhist sources. The Gelug school later became associated with the lineage of the Dalai Lamas.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **Ashvaghosha — Buddhacarita (The Life of the Buddha):** An epic poem in Sanskrit recounting the life of the Buddha, composed by the poet Aśvaghoṣa in the 1st or 2nd century CE. It follows Siddhartha Gautama from his birth and sheltered upbringing through renunciation, enlightenment, and teaching. It is among the earliest surviving complete biographies of the Buddha in Sanskrit literature.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Avatamsaka (Flower Garland) Sutra:** A large Mahayana Buddhist sutra, likely compiled in Central Asia or China by the 4th century CE from earlier component texts. It presents a vision of interpenetrating reality, illustrated by the image of Indra's net, in which each element reflects all others. It became a foundational text of the Huayan school of Chinese Buddhism.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Surangama Sutra:** A Mahayana Buddhist sutra addressing the nature of mind, perception, and meditative attainment, of disputed origin and possibly composed in China. It discusses various meditative states and the causes of delusion. It was studied within Chan (Zen) Buddhist circles for its treatment of consciousness.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

- ☐ **The Record of Linji (Rinzai Roku):** A collection of sayings and sermons attributed to Linji Yixuan, a 9th-century Chinese Chan master and founder of what became known as the Linji (Rinzai) school. It is known for its direct, iconoclastic teaching style, including the instruction to "kill the Buddha" if one is encountered as an obstacle. It is regarded as a foundational text of the Rinzai Zen tradition.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [SuttaCentral](#)

Phase VIII: Renaissance and the New Science

14th to 17th c.. About 251 hours of core reading.

The recovery of ancient texts (including the Hermetic writings, then believed older than Moses), the new political realism, the essay and the stage, and the reordering of the cosmos by Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo, and Newton. The phase ends with the philosophers who tried to rebuild knowledge on new foundations.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What did Renaissance thinkers believe they were reviving?
2. Is Machiavelli describing politics or recommending it?
3. What changed in how people knew things between Aquinas and Descartes?
4. How do Hobbes and Locke differ on the state of nature?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Petrarch — Canzoniere** (~5 h)

Read: The sonnet sequence that set the European lyric. A selection is enough.

Edition: Tr. Mark Musa (Indiana) or J.G. Nichols (Carcanet)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

2. ☐ **Hermes Trismegistus — The Corpus Hermeticum; The Emerald Tablet; Asclepius** (~6 h)

Read: Corpus Hermeticum I (Poimandres) and XIII; the Emerald Tablet. Ficino translated them in 1463.

Edition: Tr. Brian Copenhaver, *Hermetica* (Cambridge)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

3. ☐ **Pico della Mirandola — Oration on the Dignity of Man; the 900 Theses** (~3 h)

Read: The Oration: the human being as the creature with no fixed place.

Edition: Ed. Borghesi, Papio and Riva, *Oration on the Dignity of Man: A New Translation and Commentary* (Cambridge)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

4. ☐ **Niccolo Machiavelli — The Prince; Discourses on Livy** (~15 h)

Read: The Prince, then Discourses Book I. The Discourses show his republicanism.

Edition: The Prince tr. Harvey Mansfield (Chicago); Discourses tr. Mansfield and Tarcov (Chicago)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

5. ☐ **Thomas More — Utopia** (~4 h)

Read: Book I (the debate on counsel) matters as much as Book II (the island).

Edition: Ed. George Logan and Robert Adams (*Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought*)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

6. ☐ **Michel de Montaigne — Essays** (~25 h)

Read: 'That to philosophize is to learn to die', 'Of cannibals', 'Of experience', and the 'Apology for Raymond Sebond'.

Edition: Tr. M.A. Screech, *The Complete Essays* (Penguin); or Donald Frame (Stanford)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

7. ☐ **Miguel de Cervantes — Don Quixote** (~35 h)
Read: Both parts. Part II (1615) responds to Part I's readers and to a spurious sequel.
Edition: Tr. Edith Grossman (Ecco)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
8. ☐ **William Shakespeare — The Tragedies and Histories** (~40 h)
Read: Richard II, Henry IV Parts 1-2, Henry V; then Hamlet, Othello, King Lear, Macbeth.
Edition: The Arden Shakespeare, Folger Shakespeare Library, or Oxford World's Classics single volumes; Folger texts are free online
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
9. ☐ **Giordano Bruno — On the Infinite Universe and Worlds; The Ash Wednesday Supper** (~5 h)
Read: An infinite universe with innumerable worlds. Burned in Rome in 1600.
Edition: Cause, Principle and Unity, tr. Robert de Lucca (Cambridge); The Ash Wednesday Supper, tr. Gosselin and Lerner (Toronto); On the Infinite Universe in Dorothea Waley Singer, Giordano Bruno: His Life and Thought (Schuman)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
10. ☐ **Nicolaus Copernicus — On the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres** (~4 h)
Read: The dedication to Pope Paul III and Book I.
Edition: Tr. Edward Rosen, On the Revolutions (Johns Hopkins)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
11. ☐ **Johannes Kepler — Astronomia Nova; Harmonices Mundi** (~4 h)
Read: Selections on the ellipse (Astronomia Nova) and the third law (Harmonices Mundi V).
Edition: New Astronomy tr. William Donahue (Cambridge); The Harmony of the World tr. Aiton, Duncan and Field (American Philosophical Society)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
12. ☐ **Galileo Galilei — Dialogue Concerning the Two Chief World Systems** (~12 h)
Read: The First and Second Days.
Edition: Tr. Stillman Drake, Dialogue Concerning the Two Chief World Systems (Modern Library)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
13. ☐ **Francis Bacon — Novum Organum; Essays** (~8 h)
Read: Novum Organum Book I (the four idols) and a handful of the Essays.
Edition: The New Organon, ed. Jardine and Silverthorne (Cambridge); Essays (Oxford World's Classics / Penguin)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
14. ☐ **Rene Descartes — Meditations on First Philosophy; Discourse on Method** (~6 h)
Read: Discourse on Method, then all six Meditations.
Edition: Tr. John Cottingham, Meditations on First Philosophy (Cambridge); Discourse on Method tr. Donald Cress (Hackett)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
15. ☐ **Thomas Hobbes — Leviathan** (~20 h)
Read: Parts I and II. Chapter 13 on the state of nature.
Edition: Ed. Edwin Curley (Hackett); or Richard Tuck (Cambridge)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
16. ☐ **Blaise Pascal — Pensees** (~8 h)
Read: The wager (Lafuma 418), the two infinities, and the 'thinking reed'.
Edition: Tr. A.J. Krailsheimer, Pensees (Penguin), Lafuma numbering
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

17. ☐ **John Milton — Paradise Lost** (~15 h)

Read: Books I-IV and IX-XII. Compare the epic invocation with Homer and Virgil.

Edition: Ed. Gordon Teskey (Norton Critical Edition); or John Leonard (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

18. ☐ **Baruch Spinoza — Ethics** (~15 h)

Read: Parts I and V with a guide; the geometric method from Phase 1 applied to God and ethics.

Edition: A Spinoza Reader, tr. Edwin Curley (Princeton)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

19. ☐ **Isaac Newton — The Principia** (~6 h)

Read: Definitions and laws of motion, the Rules of Reasoning at the start of Book III, and the General Scholium.

Edition: Tr. I. Bernard Cohen and Anne Whitman, The Principia (California)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

20. ☐ **John Locke — An Essay Concerning Human Understanding; Two Treatises of Government** (~15 h)

Read: Second Treatise of Government in full; Essay Book II on ideas.

Edition: Two Treatises ed. Peter Laslett (Cambridge); Essay ed. Roger Woolhouse (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Synthesis. Choose one work from Phase 2 and follow its revival and transformation in this phase.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Plato — Republic; Laws:** Plato's Republic (4th century BC) constructs an ideal city ruled by philosopher-kings as an analogy for the structure of a just soul. The Laws, a later dialogue, proposes a detailed legal code as the basis of government rather than rule by an individual sage. Both works address questions of justice, education, and the organization of the state.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Aristotle — Politics; The Constitution of Athens:** Aristotle's Politics (4th century BC) classifies forms of government by who holds power and in whose interest it is exercised, and describes humans as naturally social or "political" beings. The Constitution of Athens describes the historical development and structure of the Athenian government. Aristotle favored a mixed constitution with a substantial middle class.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Cicero — On the Republic; On the Laws:** Dialogues by the Roman statesman and philosopher (106-43 BC), modeled on Plato's works, discussing the ideal mixed constitution and the basis of law in nature and reason. Cicero argues that true law is grounded in reason common to gods and humans, rather than in the decrees of rulers. Portions of both texts survive incompletely.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Augustine — The City of God:** A theological and philosophical work composed by Augustine of Hippo in the early 5th century AD, following the sack of Rome by the Visigoths in 410. It contrasts the "earthly city," organized around self-interest, with the "City of God," organized around love of God, and addresses the relationship between Christianity and Roman history. It spans twenty-two books.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Justinian — The Institutes (Corpus Juris Civilis):** A legal textbook compiled under the Byzantine emperor Justinian I and issued in 533 AD, part of the larger Corpus Juris Civilis codification of Roman law. It was intended as an introductory manual for law students. Rediscovered and studied intensively in medieval Europe, it became a basis for civil law systems in much of continental Europe.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **John of Salisbury — Policraticus:** A 12th-century treatise by an English scholar and bishop, presenting the state as a body politic with the ruler as its head. It discusses the duties of rulers and officials and includes a discussion of the conditions under which resistance to a tyrannical ruler may be justified. It is among the earliest medieval works of systematic political theory.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Marsilius of Padua — Defensor Pacis:** A political treatise written in 1324 arguing that legitimate political authority derives from the people rather than from ecclesiastical office, and that the Church should not hold coercive temporal power. It was condemned by Pope John XXII shortly after its circulation. Historians frequently cite it as an early statement of ideas associated with popular sovereignty.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Jean Bodin — Six Books of the Commonwealth:** A political treatise published in 1576 by the French jurist Jean Bodin, written during the French Wars of Religion. It develops the concept of sovereignty as the supreme, indivisible authority within a state. The work influenced later theories of the modern nation-state.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Hugo Grotius — On the Law of War and Peace:** A legal and philosophical treatise published in 1625 by the Dutch jurist Hugo Grotius. It argues for a natural law governing relations between states, including standards for the conduct of war, applicable independently of any single nation's laws. The work is regarded as a foundational text of international law.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **The Chaldean Oracles:** A collection of fragmentary verse attributed to 2nd-century figures Julian the Chaldean and Julian the Theurgist, surviving only through quotations in later Neoplatonist writings. The fragments describe cosmological and ritual teachings associated with theurgy, a practice aimed at union with the divine. They were studied by later Neoplatonist philosophers including Proclus.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **The Orphic Hymns:** A collection of eighty-seven short hymns to various deities, attributed to the mythical poet Orpheus and likely composed in the 2nd or 3rd century CE, possibly for use in ritual contexts. They are associated with Orphism, a set of religious beliefs and practices in ancient Greece concerning the soul and the afterlife. They survive as part of a broader corpus of Orphic literature.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Iamblichus — On the Mysteries:** A treatise by the Neoplatonist philosopher Iamblichus, written in the early 4th century CE, defending theurgy — ritual practice aimed at communion with the divine — as necessary alongside philosophical contemplation. It responds to a letter attributed to Porphyry questioning such practices. It is a primary source for the study of late antique theurgic ritual.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Proclus — The Elements of Theology; Platonic Theology:** Works by Proclus, a 5th-century Neoplatonist philosopher who headed the Platonic Academy in Athens. The Elements of Theology presents Neoplatonist metaphysics in a series of logically ordered propositions describing reality as emanating from and returning to a single first principle, the One. His systematic approach influenced later Christian, Islamic, and Jewish philosophical and mystical thought.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Porphyry — On the Cave of the Nymphs; Letter to Anebo:** Works by Porphyry, a 3rd-century Neoplatonist philosopher and student of Plotinus. On the Cave of the Nymphs offers an allegorical reading of a passage in Homer's Odyssey concerning the soul's descent into the material world. The Letter to Anebo raises critical questions about Egyptian ritual and theurgic practice, prompting Iamblichus's response in On the Mysteries.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **The Nag Hammadi Library — incl. The Gospel of Thomas; Pistis Sophia:** A collection of Gnostic and related texts discovered near Nag Hammadi, Egypt, in 1945, dating from roughly the 2nd to 4th centuries CE. The texts include the Gospel of Thomas, a collection of sayings attributed to Jesus, and Pistis Sophia, a later Gnostic treatise. They reflect a range of early Christian and Gnostic teachings emphasizing salvation through esoteric knowledge (gnosis).
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Zosimos of Panopolis — On the Apparatus and Furnaces:** Writings by Zosimos of Panopolis, a Greco-Egyptian alchemist active around 300 CE, among the earliest known alchemical authors. His texts combine descriptions of chemical apparatus and processes with visionary and allegorical material relating transmutation to spiritual transformation. His work is a primary source for the early history of alchemy.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Sefer Yetzirah (The Book of Formation):** An early Jewish mystical text of uncertain date, variously placed between the 2nd and 6th centuries CE, describing the creation of the world through combinations of the ten sefirot and the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet. It is among the earliest texts associated with the Kabbalistic tradition. It has been the subject of extensive later commentary. (Cross-listed in Book 18.)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **The Zohar (The Book of Splendor):** The central text of Kabbalah, a mystical commentary on the Torah written primarily in Aramaic, largely attributed to the 13th-century Spanish writer Moses de León though presented as the teaching of the 2nd-century sage Shimon bar Yochai. It discusses the sefirot, divine emanations through which the infinite (Ein Sof) relates to creation, and the mystical significance of scripture. It has been foundational to later Kabbalistic thought. (Cross-listed in Book 18.)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **The Picatrix (Ghayat al-Hakim):** A treatise on astral magic and talismans, originally composed in Arabic, likely in the 10th or 11th century, and later translated into Latin as the Picatrix. It describes methods for drawing on planetary influences through talismans, ritual, and astrology. It was influential in the transmission of Arabic magical and astrological texts to medieval and Renaissance Europe.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

- ☐ **Marsilio Ficino — Three Books on Life; the Hermetica translations:** Works by Marsilio Ficino, a 15th-century Florentine philosopher who translated Plato's dialogues and the Corpus Hermeticum into Latin. Three Books on Life addresses the health of scholars, combining medical, astrological, and magical recommendations. Ficino's translations were central to the revival of Platonic and Hermetic philosophy in Renaissance Italy.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa — Three Books of Occult Philosophy:** A systematic treatise on magic by the German scholar Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa, published in 1533. It organizes magical practice into three domains — natural, celestial, and ceremonial — drawing on classical, Hermetic, and Kabbalistic sources. It became one of the most widely referenced texts of Renaissance occult philosophy.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Paracelsus — Selected Writings:** Writings of Paracelsus, a 16th-century Swiss physician and alchemist who challenged the prevailing Galenic medical tradition in favor of chemical treatment and direct observation. He developed the concept of the human body as a microcosm corresponding to the wider natural world. His work influenced the development of both toxicology and iatrochemistry, the application of chemistry to medicine.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Robert Fludd — Utriusque Cosmi Historia:** An illustrated treatise by the English physician and Rosicrucian sympathizer Robert Fludd, published in the 1610s-1620s, presenting a detailed correspondence between the macrocosm (the universe) and the microcosm (the human being). It draws on Hermetic, alchemical, and musical theory. Its engraved diagrams are frequently reproduced as examples of early modern esoteric illustration.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **The Rosicrucian Manifestos (Fama Fraternitatis; Confessio Fraternitatis):** Anonymous pamphlets published in Germany in 1614 and 1615, announcing the existence of a secret brotherhood dedicated to spiritual and intellectual reform, associated with the legendary figure Christian Rosenkreuz. Their publication generated widespread discussion across early 17th-century Europe. No organized Rosicrucian brotherhood has been historically confirmed to have existed prior to the manifestos.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **The Key of Solomon (Clavicula Salomonis):** A grimoire, or magical text, of uncertain authorship, circulating in various manuscript versions from the medieval and Renaissance periods, traditionally attributed to King Solomon. It contains instructions, seals, and rituals for invoking and commanding spirits. It is among the most widely copied Western ceremonial magic texts.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Jakob Bohme — Aurora; The Signature of All Things:** Works by Jakob Böhme, a German shoemaker and mystic writing in the early 17th century. Aurora, his first work, describes a theological vision of God's self-revelation through the interplay of opposing forces. His writings influenced later German idealist philosophy and Christian mystical traditions, including Romanticism.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)
- ☐ **Emanuel Swedenborg — Heaven and Hell:** A 1758 work by the Swedish scientist and theologian Emanuel Swedenborg, describing his accounts of the afterlife based on visionary experiences he reported having from the 1740s onward. It presents a doctrine of "correspondences" linking the natural and spiritual worlds. His writings influenced later figures including William Blake and the Swedenborgian church movement.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#) · [ToposText](#)

Phase IX: Enlightenment to the Twentieth Century

18th to 20th c.. About 335 hours of core reading.

The critique of reason and its limits, the political revolutions and their critics, evolution, the unconscious, and the physics of the twentieth century. The phase ends with the mid-century thinkers who wrote after the world wars.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What does Kant mean by a Copernican revolution in philosophy?
2. Burke and Tocqueville both study revolution. What does each fear?
3. What does Nietzsche mean by the death of God, and who else in this phase is answering the same problem?
4. How did Darwin and the new physics change the questions philosophers asked?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz — Monadology** (~2 h)

Read: Ninety short sections; the best possible world.

Edition: In *Philosophical Essays*, tr. Ariew and Garber (Hackett)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

2. ☐ **Giambattista Vico — The New Science** (~12 h)

Read: The Elements (axioms) and the three ages of gods, heroes, and men.

Edition: Tr. Bergin and Fisch (Cornell); or David Marsh (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

3. ☐ **David Hume — A Treatise of Human Nature; Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding** (~12 h)

Read: *Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* in full; *Treatise* Book I Part IV on personal identity.

Edition: *Enquiry* ed. Tom Beauchamp (Oxford); *Treatise* ed. Norton and Norton (Oxford)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

4. ☐ **Montesquieu — The Spirit of the Laws** (~12 h)

Read: Books I-VIII on the three forms of government and Book XI on the separation of powers.

Edition: Tr. Cohler, Miller and Stone (Cambridge)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

5. ☐ **Voltaire — Candide; Philosophical Dictionary** (~4 h)

Read: *Candide*, written in answer to Leibniz.

Edition: *Candide* tr. Theo Cuffe (Penguin) or Robert M. Adams (Norton)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

6. ☐ **Jean-Jacques Rousseau — The Social Contract; Emile; Confessions** (~12 h)

Read: *The Social Contract*; the first books of *Emile* and the *Confessions*.

Edition: *The Social Contract* and *Other Later Political Writings*, ed. Victor Gourevitch (Cambridge); *Emile* tr. Allan Bloom (Basic Books)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

7. ☐ **Adam Smith — The Theory of Moral Sentiments; The Wealth of Nations** (~20 h)
 Read: Theory of Moral Sentiments Part I first, then Wealth of Nations Book I.
 Edition: Theory of Moral Sentiments (Penguin / Liberty Fund); Wealth of Nations (Oxford World's Classics / Liberty Fund)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
8. ☐ **Immanuel Kant — Critique of Pure Reason; of Practical Reason; of Judgment; Groundwork** (~30 h)
 Read: Groundwork first; then the two Prefaces, Introduction, and Transcendental Aesthetic of the first Critique.
 Edition: Groundwork tr. Mary Gregor (Cambridge); Critique of Pure Reason tr. Guyer and Wood (Cambridge) or Werner Pluhar (Hackett)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
9. ☐ **Edmund Burke — Reflections on the Revolution in France** (~8 h)
 Read: Written in 1790, before the Terror. His argument on inherited institutions.
 Edition: Ed. J.G.A. Pocock (Hackett); or L.G. Mitchell (Oxford World's Classics)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
10. ☐ **Alexis de Tocqueville — Democracy in America** (~25 h)
 Read: Volume I Part II ch. 7 (tyranny of the majority); Volume II Part IV on soft despotism.
 Edition: Tr. Harvey Mansfield and Delba Winthrop (Chicago)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
11. ☐ **Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel — The Phenomenology of Spirit; Science of Logic; Philosophy of Right** (~25 h)
 Read: The Preface and the lordship-and-bondage section (paras. 178-196) of the Phenomenology, then the Philosophy of Right.
 Edition: Phenomenology tr. A.V. Miller (Oxford), paragraph numbers as cited; Philosophy of Right ed. Allen Wood (Cambridge)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
12. ☐ **Arthur Schopenhauer — The World as Will and Representation; Essays and Aphorisms** (~12 h)
 Read: World as Will Book IV, then a selection of the Essays.
 Edition: Tr. E.F.J. Payne, The World as Will and Representation (Dover, 2 vols.); Essays and Aphorisms tr. R.J. Hollingdale (Penguin)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
13. ☐ **Soren Kierkegaard — Fear and Trembling; Either/Or; The Sickness Unto Death** (~10 h)
 Read: Fear and Trembling on Abraham and Isaac (Genesis 22 from Phase 4).
 Edition: Tr. Alastair Hannay, Fear and Trembling (Penguin); or Hong and Hong (Princeton)
 Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
14. ☐ **Karl Marx — Capital; Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts** (~15 h)
 Read: The 1844 Manuscripts on estranged labor; Capital Volume I, chapter 1 and Part VIII.
 Edition: The Marx-Engels Reader, ed. Robert Tucker (Norton); Capital vol. 1 tr. Ben Fowkes (Penguin)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
15. ☐ **Charles Darwin — On the Origin of Species; The Voyage of the Beagle** (~15 h)
 Read: Origin chapters 1-4 and 14 (recapitulation and conclusion).
 Edition: On the Origin of Species, 1st edition (1859), Penguin Classics or Oxford World's Classics
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
16. ☐ **Friedrich Nietzsche — The Birth of Tragedy; On the Genealogy of Morals; The Gay Science** (~12 h)
 Read: Birth of Tragedy (it returns to Phase 2), Genealogy essay I, Gay Science 125 (the madman).
 Edition: Basic Writings of Nietzsche, tr. Walter Kaufmann (Modern Library); The Gay Science tr. Kaufmann (Vintage)
 Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

17. ☐ **William James — The Principles of Psychology; The Varieties of Religious Experience** (~12 h)
- Read: The Varieties: lectures on the sick soul, conversion, and mysticism.
Edition: The Varieties of Religious Experience (Penguin / Library of America)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
18. ☐ **Sigmund Freud — The Interpretation of Dreams; Civilization and Its Discontents** (~12 h)
- Read: Civilization and Its Discontents in full; Interpretation of Dreams chapter 2.
Edition: Standard Edition, tr. James Strachey: Civilization and Its Discontents (Norton); The Interpretation of Dreams (Basic Books)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
19. ☐ **Carl Gustav Jung — The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious; Aion; Answer to Job; Memories, Dreams, Reflections** (~12 h)
- Read: Memories, Dreams, Reflections first, then Answer to Job (after Phase 4's Job).
Edition: Memories, Dreams, Reflections, ed. Aniela Jaffe (Vintage); Answer to Job (Princeton, Bollingen)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
20. ☐ **Albert Einstein — Relativity: The Special and the General Theory** (~5 h)
- Read: Einstein's own popular account. Part I (special relativity).
Edition: Relativity: The Special and the General Theory, tr. Robert Lawson (Penguin / Crown)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
21. ☐ **Werner Heisenberg — Physics and Philosophy** (~5 h)
- Read: The Copenhagen interpretation and his comparison with Greek natural philosophy.
Edition: Physics and Philosophy (Harper Perennial Modern Classics)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
22. ☐ **Erwin Schrodinger — What Is Life?** (~3 h)
- Read: The 1943 lectures that influenced the discovery of DNA's structure.
Edition: What Is Life? (Cambridge, Canto Classics)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
23. ☐ **Martin Heidegger — Being and Time** (~25 h)
- Read: Introduction and Division I with a guide; Division II on death and authenticity.
Edition: Tr. Macquarrie and Robinson (Harper) or Joan Stambaugh (SUNY). Guide: Hubert Dreyfus, Being-in-the-World (MIT)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
24. ☐ **Ludwig Wittgenstein — Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus; Philosophical Investigations** (~15 h)
- Read: The Tractatus (short, dense), then Investigations sections 1-133.
Edition: Tractatus tr. Pears and McGuinness (Routledge); Philosophical Investigations tr. Anscombe, Hacker and Schulte (Wiley-Blackwell)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
25. ☐ **Simone Weil — Gravity and Grace; Waiting for God** (~5 h)
- Read: Gravity and Grace is a compilation of notebook entries; read slowly.
Edition: Gravity and Grace, tr. Emma Crawford and Mario von der Ruhr (Routledge Classics)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
26. ☐ **Hannah Arendt — The Human Condition; The Origins of Totalitarianism** (~15 h)
- Read: The Human Condition: labor, work, and action. Origins Part III if time allows.
Edition: The Human Condition, 2nd ed. (Chicago); The Origins of Totalitarianism (Harcourt / Penguin)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Synthesis. Trace the modern answer to 'what is a human being?' from Hume and Kant through Darwin, Freud, and Heidegger.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Benoit Mandelbrot — The Fractal Geometry of Nature; The (Mis)Behavior of Markets:** Works by mathematician Benoit Mandelbrot on fractal geometry, patterns that display self-similarity across different scales. The Fractal Geometry of Nature (1982) applies this framework to natural forms such as coastlines and clouds; The (Mis)Behavior of Markets (2004) applies related ideas to financial price movements.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Henri Poincare — Science and Hypothesis; The Value of Science:** Essay collections by mathematician and physicist Henri Poincare, published in the early twentieth century, on the philosophy of science. They examine the role of convention, hypothesis, and intuition in mathematics and physics, including reflections on questions later associated with relativity and chaos theory.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **D'Arcy Wentworth Thompson — On Growth and Form:** A 1917 book by the Scottish biologist and mathematician D'Arcy Wentworth Thompson, analyzing biological form through physical and mathematical principles. It discusses examples including the logarithmic spiral of shells and the scaling of skeletal structure, arguing that physical forces shape organic growth alongside natural selection.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Richard Feynman — The Character of Physical Law; QED:** Books based on public lectures by physicist Richard Feynman. The Character of Physical Law (1965) discusses the nature of physical laws and the scientific method using examples from gravitation and conservation principles; QED (1985) explains the theory of quantum electrodynamics for a general audience.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **James Gleick — Chaos: Making a New Science:** A 1987 popular science book by James Gleick describing the development of chaos theory. It covers topics including the butterfly effect, strange attractors, and fractal geometry, and profiles scientists who contributed to the field in the 1960s and 1970s.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **G.H. Hardy — A Mathematician's Apology:** A 1940 essay by mathematician G.H. Hardy reflecting on the nature and value of mathematics, particularly pure mathematics pursued without practical application. It discusses mathematical aesthetics and the criteria, such as elegance and depth, by which mathematicians judge their work.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Primo Levi — The Periodic Table:** A 1975 memoir by chemist and writer Primo Levi, structured as twenty-one chapters each named after a chemical element. It combines autobiographical episodes, including his imprisonment at Auschwitz, with reflections drawn from his career as an industrial chemist.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **George Berkeley — Principles of Human Knowledge:** A 1710 work by the Irish philosopher and bishop George Berkeley, presenting the idealist position that material objects exist only as they are perceived (summarized in the phrase "esse est percipi," to be is to be perceived). Berkeley argued that the continued existence of unperceived objects depends on their being perceived by God. It is a foundational text of subjective idealism.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Johann Gottlieb Fichte — The Science of Knowledge:** A philosophical work by Johann Gottlieb Fichte, first published in 1794, developing a system of transcendental idealism building on Kant's philosophy. Fichte grounds his system in an active, self-positing "I" that constitutes both itself and its experience of the world. He was an early figure in German Idealism.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Friedrich Schelling — System of Transcendental Idealism:** An 1800 work by the German philosopher Friedrich Wilhelm Joseph Schelling, part of the German Idealist tradition. It discusses the relationship between nature and self-consciousness and gives particular attention to the role of art as a point where conscious and unconscious activity converge. Schelling's philosophy of nature influenced German Romantic thought.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Henri Bergson — Creative Evolution:** A 1907 work by the French philosopher Henri Bergson, which distinguishes lived, qualitative time (duration) from the quantitative time measured by clocks. It presents evolution as driven by a creative impulse he called the *élan vital*. Bergson received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1927.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Edmund Husserl — Cartesian Meditations:** A work by the German philosopher Edmund Husserl, based on lectures delivered in 1929, presenting an introduction to his method of phenomenology. It describes the practice of bracketing (*epoché*) assumptions about the external world in order to examine the structures of consciousness directly. Husserl is regarded as the founder of phenomenology as a philosophical method.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Jean-Paul Sartre — Being and Nothingness:** A 1943 philosophical work by the French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre, a major text of existentialist philosophy. It argues that existence precedes essence, meaning humans are not born with a fixed nature but define themselves through their choices, and discusses the concept of "bad faith" as self-deception about one's freedom. Sartre also addresses the human search for meaning without recourse to essentialist or theistic frameworks.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Alfred Adler — Understanding Human Nature:** A 1927 work by the Austrian psychiatrist Alfred Adler, another early associate of Freud who developed the school of individual psychology. It presents his theory that personality development centers on overcoming feelings of inferiority and seeking social belonging, introducing the concept of the "inferiority complex." Adler emphasized social interest and practical engagement as markers of psychological health.

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Phase X: The Modern Imagination

18th to 20th c.. About 397 hours of core reading.

The novel, the lyric, and the drama of the last three centuries, read now because they respond to everything before them. Tolstoy and Dostoevsky answer Phase 9; Joyce rewrites the Odyssey; Eliot's Four Quartets draws on Phase 5's mystics; Tolkien draws on Phase 5's Norse and Anglo-Saxon material.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. What can the novel do that epic and tragedy could not?
2. How do Dostoevsky and Nietzsche respond differently to the same crisis?
3. Which ancient or medieval works does each modern writer rewrite?
4. How do the twentieth-century writers treat war?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Johann Wolfgang von Goethe — Faust; The Sorrows of Young Werther** (~12 h)

Read: Faust Part One in full; Part Two in selection.

Edition: Faust tr. Walter Arndt (Norton Critical Edition) or David Luke (Oxford World's Classics)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

2. ☐ **William Blake — Songs of Innocence and of Experience; The Marriage of Heaven and Hell** (~3 h)

Read: Paired poems: The Lamb and The Tyger.

Edition: Blake's Poetry and Designs (Norton Critical Edition); the William Blake Archive online shows the illuminated plates

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

3. ☐ **William Wordsworth — The Prelude; Lyrical Ballads** (~6 h)

Read: The 1802 Preface to Lyrical Ballads, 'Tintern Abbey', and Prelude Books I-II.

Edition: Wordsworth's Poetry and Prose (Norton Critical Edition); The Prelude 1799, 1805, 1850 (Norton)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

4. ☐ **Jane Austen — Pride and Prejudice; Emma** (~10 h)

Read: Pride and Prejudice, then Emma.

Edition: Penguin Classics or Oxford World's Classics

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

5. ☐ **Aleksandr Pushkin — Eugene Onegin** (~5 h)

Read: A novel in verse; the founding work of Russian literature.

Edition: Tr. James E. Folen (Oxford World's Classics) or Stanley Mitchell (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

6. ☐ **Herman Melville — Moby-Dick** (~20 h)

Read: Read the cetology chapters; they carry the book's argument.

Edition: Norton Critical Edition or Penguin Classics

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

7. ☐ **Gustave Flaubert — Madame Bovary; Sentimental Education** (~10 h)
- Read: Madame Bovary: Emma's reading shapes her life.
Edition: Tr. Lydia Davis (Penguin) or Margaret Mauldon (Oxford World's Classics)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
8. ☐ **Leo Tolstoy — War and Peace; Anna Karenina; The Death of Ivan Ilyich** (~45 h)
- Read: The Death of Ivan Ilyich first, then Anna Karenina, then War and Peace.
Edition: Tr. Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky (Vintage), or Louise and Aylmer Maude (Oxford World's Classics)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
9. ☐ **Dostoevsky — Crime and Punishment; The Brothers Karamazov; Demons; The Idiot; Notes from Underground** (~45 h)
- Read: Notes from Underground, Crime and Punishment, The Brothers Karamazov (the Grand Inquisitor: Book V ch. 5).
Edition: Tr. Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky (Vintage)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
10. ☐ **George Eliot — Middlemarch** (~25 h)
- Read: Middlemarch in full; the Finale is essential.
Edition: Penguin Classics or Oxford World's Classics
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
11. ☐ **Friedrich Nietzsche — Thus Spoke Zarathustra; Beyond Good and Evil** (~10 h)
- Read: Zarathustra's Prologue, then Beyond Good and Evil Parts 1 and 9.
Edition: Zarathustra tr. Walter Kaufmann (in The Portable Nietzsche, Penguin); Beyond Good and Evil tr. Kaufmann (Vintage)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
12. ☐ **Anton Chekhov — Selected Stories and Plays** (~8 h)
- Read: 'The Lady with the Dog', 'Ward No. 6'; The Cherry Orchard.
Edition: Stories tr. Pevear and Volokhonsky (Bantam); plays tr. Paul Schmidt (Harper)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
13. ☐ **Joseph Conrad — Heart of Darkness; Lord Jim** (~6 h)
- Read: Heart of Darkness first.
Edition: Norton Critical Edition or Penguin Classics
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
14. ☐ **Kafka — The Trial; The Castle; The Metamorphosis; Diaries** (~10 h)
- Read: The Metamorphosis, then The Trial.
Edition: The Metamorphosis tr. Susan Bernofsky (Norton); The Trial tr. Breon Mitchell (Schocken)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
15. ☐ **Rainer Maria Rilke — Duino Elegies** (~3 h)
- Read: The First and Ninth Elegies.
Edition: Tr. Stephen Mitchell, in The Selected Poetry of Rainer Maria Rilke (Vintage)
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
16. ☐ **Marcel Proust — In Search of Lost Time** (~30 h)
- Read: Swann's Way; continue if it holds.
Edition: Tr. Moncrieff and Kilmartin, rev. D.J. Enright (Modern Library); Swann's Way tr. Lydia Davis (Penguin)
Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

17. ☐ **James Joyce — Ulysses; A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man** (~25 h)

Read: Portrait first. Read Ulysses with a chapter guide after the Odyssey (Phase 2).

Edition: Ulysses, Gabler edition (Vintage), with Don Gifford, Ulysses Annotated (California); A Portrait (Penguin)

Find it: [Free public-domain text](#) (Gutenberg search) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

18. ☐ **Thomas Mann — The Magic Mountain; Death in Venice; Doctor Faustus** (~25 h)

Read: Death in Venice, then The Magic Mountain.

Edition: Tr. John E. Woods, The Magic Mountain (Vintage); Death in Venice tr. Michael Henry Heim (Ecco)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

19. ☐ **T.S. Eliot — The Waste Land; Four Quartets** (~4 h)

Read: The Waste Land with its notes; Four Quartets draws on The Cloud of Unknowing and Julian of Norwich.

Edition: Collected Poems 1909-1962 (Faber / Harcourt); The Waste Land Norton Critical Edition

Find it: [Free public-domain text](#) (Gutenberg search) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

20. ☐ **G.K. Chesterton — Orthodoxy; The Everlasting Man** (~6 h)

Read: Orthodoxy: a defense of belief against the thinkers of Phase 9.

Edition: Orthodoxy (Ignatius / Moody); The Everlasting Man (Ignatius)

Find it: [Free public-domain text](#) (Gutenberg search) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

21. ☐ **C.S. Lewis — The Abolition of Man; Till We Have Faces** (~6 h)

Read: The Abolition of Man (on the Tao across traditions) and Till We Have Faces (Cupid and Psyche from Apuleius, Phase 3).

Edition: The Abolition of Man (HarperOne); Till We Have Faces (Harcourt / HarperOne)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

22. ☐ **Ernst Junger — Storm of Steel; On the Marble Cliffs** (~8 h)

Read: Storm of Steel: a German infantry officer's memoir of the Western Front.

Edition: Tr. Michael Hofmann, Storm of Steel (Penguin)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

23. ☐ **Albert Camus — The Stranger; The Myth of Sisyphus** (~5 h)

Read: The Stranger, then The Myth of Sisyphus.

Edition: The Stranger tr. Matthew Ward (Vintage); The Myth of Sisyphus tr. Justin O'Brien (Vintage)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

24. ☐ **Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn — The Gulag Archipelago; One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich** (~30 h)

Read: One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich first; The Gulag Archipelago in the one-volume abridgment.

Edition: One Day tr. H.T. Willetts (Farrar, Straus and Giroux); The Gulag Archipelago, one-volume abridgment by Edward E. Ericson Jr. (Harper Perennial)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

25. ☐ **Tolkien — The Lord of the Rings; The Silmarillion; The Hobbit** (~40 h)

Read: The Hobbit, then The Lord of the Rings. Note what it borrows from Beowulf, the Eddas, and the Kalevala.

Edition: HarperCollins or Houghton Mifflin editions

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Synthesis. Pick one modern work and map its sources back through at least three earlier phases.

Deeper shelf

- ☐ **Mishima — The Sea of Fertility; Confessions of a Mask; Sun and Steel; Patriotism:** Yukio Mishima (1925-1970) was a Japanese novelist and essayist. The Sea of Fertility is a four-novel cycle following reincarnation across twentieth-century Japan; Confessions of a Mask is a semi-autobiographical novel about a young man's concealed identity. Sun and Steel is a memoir-essay on bodybuilding and physical discipline, and Patriotism is a short story about a military officer's ritual suicide; Mishima died by seppuku in 1970 after a failed coup attempt.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Knut Hamsun — Hunger; Growth of the Soil:** Knut Hamsun (1859-1952) was a Norwegian novelist. Hunger (1890) is a first-person narrative depicting a starving writer's deteriorating mental state in Christiania (Oslo); Growth of the Soil (1917), for which Hamsun received the Nobel Prize in Literature, follows a settler establishing a farm in rural Norway. Hamsun's later support for Nazi Germany during World War II remains a subject of biographical discussion.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Louis-Ferdinand Celine — Journey to the End of the Night:** Louis-Ferdinand Celine (1894-1961) was a French novelist. Journey to the End of the Night (1932) follows its narrator through World War I, colonial Africa, the United States, and postwar France, written in a colloquial, slang-inflected style. Celine's later writings included antisemitic pamphlets, a fact widely discussed alongside his literary work.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Hermann Hesse — Siddhartha; The Glass Bead Game:** Hermann Hesse (1877-1962) was a German-Swiss writer. Siddhartha (1922) follows a man in ancient India across various stages of spiritual searching, including asceticism, worldly life, and eventual settlement by a river. The Glass Bead Game (1943), his final novel, is set in a future intellectual order centered on an abstract synthesis of the arts and sciences.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Georges Bernanos — The Diary of a Country Priest:** Georges Bernanos (1888-1948) was a French Catholic novelist. The Diary of a Country Priest (1936) is written as the journal of a young, physically ill priest serving an unwelcoming rural parish in northern France. The novel addresses themes of vocation, suffering, and grace.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Evelyn Waugh — Brideshead Revisited:** Evelyn Waugh (1903-1966) was an English novelist. Brideshead Revisited (1945) follows the narrator Charles Ryder's relationship, over roughly two decades, with the aristocratic and Catholic Flyte family. The novel addresses memory, class, and religious belief in early-to-mid twentieth-century England.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Stendhal — The Red and the Black:** Stendhal (Marie-Henri Beyle, 1783-1842) was a French novelist. The Red and the Black (1830) follows Julien Sorel, a carpenter's son who advances through French society via the church and the aristocracy in the years following the Napoleonic era. The novel is known for its use of psychological interiority.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Honore de Balzac — Pere Goriot; Lost Illusions:** Honore de Balzac (1799-1850) was a French novelist whose works were collected under the title The Human Comedy, a project intended to depict French society comprehensively after the Revolution. Pere Goriot (1835) follows an elderly man impoverished by his devotion to his two daughters; Lost Illusions (1837-43) follows a young provincial poet's entry into Parisian literary and journalistic life.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Victor Hugo — Les Miserables; The Hunchback of Notre-Dame:** Victor Hugo (1802-1885) was a French novelist and poet. *Les Miserables* (1862) follows Jean Valjean, a former convict, across several decades of nineteenth-century France, addressing poverty, law, and redemption. *The Hunchback of Notre-Dame* (1831) is set in fifteenth-century Paris and centers on the bell-ringer Quasimodo and the cathedral of Notre-Dame.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Nikolai Gogol — Dead Souls; The Overcoat:** Nikolai Gogol (1809-1852) was a Russian writer of Ukrainian origin. *Dead Souls* (1842) follows a con man who travels the Russian provinces buying the legal titles to deceased serfs; *The Overcoat* (1842) is a short story about a poor clerk who saves for a new coat, only to have it stolen. Both works are noted for their satirical treatment of Russian bureaucracy.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **William Faulkner — The Sound and the Fury; Absalom, Absalom!:** William Faulkner (1897-1962) was an American novelist. *The Sound and the Fury* (1929) and *Absalom, Absalom!* (1936) are set in the fictional Yoknapatawpha County, Mississippi, and use non-linear narration and multiple narrators to depict the decline of Southern families across generations. Faulkner received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1949.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Moliere — The Misanthrope; Tartuffe:** Moliere (Jean-Baptiste Poquelin, 1622-1673) was a French playwright and actor. *Tartuffe* (1664) concerns a household deceived by a religious hypocrite who ingratiates himself with its head; *The Misanthrope* (1666) follows a man who rejects the social conventions and flattery of his circle. Both are verse comedies addressing hypocrisy and manners in seventeenth-century French society.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Jean Racine — Phedre; Andromache:** Jean Racine (1639-1699) was a French playwright associated with classical tragedy. *Phedre* (1677) dramatizes the story of Phaedra's forbidden love for her stepson Hippolytus, drawn from Greek mythology via Euripides and Seneca; *Andromache* (1667) follows the widow of Hector after the fall of Troy. Both plays follow the conventions of French neoclassical drama, including the unities of time, place, and action.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Charles Baudelaire — Les Fleurs du Mal:** Charles Baudelaire (1821-1867) was a French poet. *Les Fleurs du Mal* (*The Flowers of Evil*), first published in 1857, is a collection of poems addressing urban life, beauty, sin, and mortality; parts of the original edition were prosecuted for obscenity under French law. The collection is often cited as an influence on later French Symbolist poetry.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Walt Whitman — Leaves of Grass:** Walt Whitman (1819-1892) was an American poet. *Leaves of Grass*, first published in 1855 and revised across multiple editions through 1892, is a collection of poems written largely in free verse addressing democracy, the body, nature, and American national identity. "Song of Myself" is its best-known individual poem.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Friedrich Holderlin — Hymns and Fragments:** Friedrich Holderlin (1770-1843) was a German poet. His hymns and later fragmentary poems, written between the 1790s and around 1806 when he began to suffer from mental illness, address classical Greek mythology, the divine, and the German landscape. His work received renewed critical attention in the twentieth century, including commentary by the philosopher Martin Heidegger.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Jaroslav Hasek — The Good Soldier Svejk:** Jaroslav Hasek (1883-1923) was a Czech writer. The Good Soldier Svejk, published in installments beginning in 1921 and left unfinished at Hasek's death, follows a soldier in the Austro-Hungarian army during World War I whose exaggerated compliance and apparent simple-mindedness disrupt military bureaucracy. It is written in a comic, episodic style and satirizes military and imperial institutions.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Samuel Taylor Coleridge — The Rime of the Ancient Mariner:** Samuel Taylor Coleridge (1772-1834) was an English poet and critic. The Rime of the Ancient Mariner, first published in the 1798 Lyrical Ballads, is a narrative ballad about a sailor who kills an albatross and is subsequently cursed, undergoing a period of suffering and eventual partial redemption. It employs archaic language and a supernatural narrative frame.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Lord Byron — Don Juan; Childe Harold's Pilgrimage:** Lord Byron (George Gordon Byron, 1788-1824) was an English poet. Childe Harold's Pilgrimage (1812-18) is a narrative poem following a disillusioned young traveler through Europe and popularized the archetype later termed the "Byronic hero." Don Juan (1819-24, unfinished) is a lengthy satirical narrative poem in comic verse.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Percy Bysshe Shelley — Prometheus Unbound:** Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792-1822) was an English Romantic poet. Prometheus Unbound (1820) is a lyrical drama reworking the Greek myth of Prometheus, in which the title figure is eventually freed and tyranny is overthrown; it reflects Shelley's political radicalism and interest in themes of liberty.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **John Keats — The Great Odes; Hyperion:** John Keats (1795-1821) was an English Romantic poet who died of tuberculosis at age twenty-five. His major odes, including "Ode to a Nightingale," "Ode on a Grecian Urn," and "To Autumn," were written in 1819 and address beauty, mortality, and time. Hyperion is an unfinished epic poem on the overthrow of the Titans by the Olympian gods.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Alfred, Lord Tennyson — Idylls of the King; In Memoriam:** Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1809-1892) was the British Poet Laureate for much of the Victorian era. In Memoriam A.H.H. (1850) is a long elegy written over some seventeen years following the death of his close friend Arthur Hallam. Idylls of the King (1859-85) is a cycle of narrative poems retelling the Arthurian legend.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Emily Dickinson — The Complete Poems:** Emily Dickinson (1830-1886) was an American poet who spent most of her life in Amherst, Massachusetts, and published almost none of her roughly 1,800 poems during her lifetime. Her poems, most written in short, irregular stanzas with distinctive punctuation, address subjects including death, nature, and the mind. They were collected and published posthumously, beginning in 1890.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **William Butler Yeats — The Tower; Collected Poems:** William Butler Yeats (1865-1939) was an Irish poet and a leading figure in Irish literary and cultural life. His work spans early poems drawing on Irish myth and folklore to later collections, including The Tower (1928), addressing aging, Irish politics, and his personal symbolic system. "The Second Coming" (1919) is among his most frequently cited poems; Yeats received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1923.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

- ☐ **Fernando Pessoa — The Book of Disquiet; the heteronym poems:** Fernando Pessoa (1888-1935) was a Portuguese writer who composed much of his work under invented authorial personas, or "heteronyms," each with a distinct biography and style. The Book of Disquiet, assembled and published posthumously, is a fragmentary prose work presented as the reflections of a Lisbon office worker. Most of Pessoa's writing was published only after his death.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Federico Garcia Lorca — Gypsy Ballads (Romancero Gitano):** Federico Garcia Lorca (1898-1936) was a Spanish poet and playwright from Andalusia. Gypsy Ballads (1928) is a collection of narrative poems drawing on Andalusian folk balladry, the Andalusian landscape, and Romani culture. Lorca was killed in 1936 during the early months of the Spanish Civil War.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Pablo Neruda — Canto General:** Pablo Neruda (1904-1973) was a Chilean poet and diplomat. Canto General (1950) is a long poem in multiple sections addressing the history, geography, and peoples of Latin America, including a section devoted to the Inca site of Machu Picchu. Neruda received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1971.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Charles Dickens — Bleak House; Great Expectations; David Copperfield:** Charles Dickens (1812-1870) was an English novelist whose works were largely published serially. Bleak House (1852-53) centers on a protracted Chancery lawsuit and addresses the English legal system; Great Expectations (1860-61) and David Copperfield (1849-50) are bildungsromans following their protagonists from childhood into adulthood. His novels frequently address poverty and social conditions in Victorian England.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Henrik Ibsen — A Doll's House; Hedda Gabler; Peer Gynt:** Henrik Ibsen (1828-1906) was a Norwegian playwright. A Doll's House (1879) and Hedda Gabler (1890) are realist dramas addressing marriage, gender roles, and social convention in bourgeois households; Peer Gynt (1867) is an earlier verse drama following a wandering, self-mythologizing protagonist through fantastical episodes. Ibsen is frequently discussed as a significant figure in the development of modern realist theater.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Giuseppe di Lampedusa — The Leopard:** Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa (1896-1957) was an Italian, Sicilian nobleman and writer. The Leopard, published posthumously in 1958, follows a Sicilian aristocrat, Don Fabrizio, and his family during and after Garibaldi's unification campaign in 1860s Sicily. The novel addresses the decline of the old Sicilian aristocracy amid political and social change.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)
- ☐ **Yasunari Kawabata — Snow Country:** Yasunari Kawabata (1899-1972) was a Japanese novelist. Snow Country, published in stages between 1935 and 1947, follows a relationship between a Tokyo dilettante and a geisha in a remote hot-spring town in the mountains of western Japan. Kawabata received the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1968.
Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Phase XI: Capstone: The Forbidden Shelf

18th to 20th c.. About 69 hours of core reading.

Works associated with controversial or extremist positions, placed last so they can be read against the full tradition they argue with. Recommended preparation: Plato's Republic, Hobbes, Burke, Hegel, Marx, and Nietzsche. Read each alongside a critical introduction or a serious critic, and note which earlier works each author claims or distorts.

Questions to carry through the phase

1. Which earlier work does each author claim as precedent, and is the reading faithful?
2. What does each author take to be the root problem of modernity?
3. Where does each argument depend on an assumption it does not defend?

Core sequence

1. ☐ **Marquis de Sade — Philosophy in the Bedroom** (~5 h)

Read: The interpolated pamphlet 'Yet Another Effort, Frenchmen' states the political argument.

Edition: In Justine, Philosophy in the Bedroom, and Other Writings, tr. Seaver and Wainhouse (Grove)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

2. ☐ **Joseph de Maistre — St. Petersburg Dialogues; Considerations on France** (~8 h)

Read: Considerations on France (1797): providence and the Revolution. Read against Burke.

Edition: Considerations on France, tr. Richard Lebrun (Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

3. ☐ **Max Stirner — The Ego and Its Own** (~10 h)

Read: Egoism against Feuerbach and Hegel. Marx and Engels answered it in The German Ideology.

Edition: Ed. David Leopold, The Ego and Its Own (Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought)

Find it: [Free public-domain text \(Gutenberg search\)](#) · [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

4. ☐ **Georges Sorel — Reflections on Violence** (~8 h)

Read: The theory of the political myth of the general strike.

Edition: Ed. Jeremy Jennings, Reflections on Violence (Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

5. ☐ **Oswald Spengler — The Decline of the West** (~15 h)

Read: The Introduction and the morphology of cultures. Compare with Vico and Ibn Khaldun.

Edition: Tr. Charles Francis Atkinson (Knopf / Oxford), abridged one-volume edition

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

6. ☐ **Carl Schmitt — The Concept of the Political; Political Theology** (~6 h)

Read: The friend-enemy distinction; sovereignty as the decision on the exception. Compare with Hobbes.

Edition: The Concept of the Political, tr. George Schwab (Chicago); Political Theology, tr. Schwab (Chicago)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

7. ☐ **Julius Evola — Revolt Against the Modern World; Ride the Tiger; Men Among the Ruins** (~12 h)

Read: Revolt Against the Modern World Part I. Note how he uses Phase 7 and the Hermetic sources.

Edition: Tr. Guido Stucco, Revolt Against the Modern World (Inner Traditions). Critical context: Mark Sedgwick, Against the Modern World (Oxford)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

8. ☐ **E.M. Cioran — A Short History of Decay; The Trouble with Being Born** (~5 h)

Read: Aphorisms. Compare with Pascal and Schopenhauer.

Edition: A Short History of Decay and The Trouble with Being Born, tr. Richard Howard (Arcade)

Find it: [Open Library](#) · [Internet Archive](#) · [Project Gutenberg](#)

Synthesis. Choose one author and write the strongest response to them from within the earlier phases.

Deeper shelf